

Chapter Thirty-Eight of the Noble Great Jewel Heap: The Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Requested by the Bodhisattva Sublime Gnosis, Skilled in the Great Secret Skillful Means of All Buddhas

Āryasarvabuddhamahārahasyopāyakaśālyajñānottarabodhisattvapariṣcchāparivartanā
mamahāyānasūtra · Toh 82 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་དཀའ་མཆོག་བརྟེན་པ་ཆེ་པའི་ཆོས་ཀྱི་སྒྲིམ་གྲས་ལའི་སྤྱོད་པ་བརྟེན་པ་ལས་ལའི་སྤྱོད་ཅ་རྩ་
བརྟེན་པ་སྤྱིངས་རྟེན་ཐམས་ཅད་ཀྱི་སྤྱིང་ཆེ་ཐབས་ལ་མཁས་པ་བརྟེན་ཆུ་སེམས་དཔའ་ཡ་ཤེས་དམ་པས་
ཞུ་པ།

Toh 82 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Āryasarvabuddhamahārahasyopāyakaśālyajñānottarabodhisattvapariṣcchā and in Tibetan as the chapter requested by the bodhisattva Sublime Gnosis, skilled in the great secret skillful means of all buddhas. It forms Chapter Thirty-Eight of the vast collection known as the Great Jewel Heap, or Ratnakūṭa, a compendium of one hundred thousand chapters of Dharma teachings, and is itself classified as a Mahāyāna sūtra belonging to that broader canonical grouping. The text is set in the familiar scene of the Buddha residing in the Jeta Grove at Śrāvastī among a great assembly, and its teachings are framed as a dialogue prompted by the bodhisattva Sublime Gnosis, whose particular concern is the profound and secret dimension of skillful means common to all buddhas. As part of the Ratnakūṭa collection, it belongs to one of the most important sutra groupings in the Kangyur, bringing together a wide range of Mahāyāna doctrinal perspectives under the theme of the precious heap of Dharma.

From the Noble Great Jewel Heap of Dharma Synonyms in One Hundred Thousand Chapters: Chapter Thirty-Eight, the Sūtra of the Great Vehicle — requested by the bodhisattva Sublime Gnosis, who is skilled in the great secret skillful means of all buddhas. First fascicle.

In the language of India: Āryasarvabuddhamahārahasyopāyakaśālyajñānodta rabodhisattvapariṣcchāparivartanāmamahāyānasūtra.

In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra called "The Chapter Requested by the Bodhisattva Sublime Gnosis, Skilled in the Great Secret Skillful Means of All Buddhas."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, in the park of Prince Jeta. He was accompanied by a great Saṅgha of eight thousand monks, both those still in training and those beyond training, and by sixteen thousand great bodhisattvas, every one of whom had attained the superknowledges and obtained dhāraṇī, whose eloquence was unobstructed, who were skilled in the accomplishment of superknowledges, who had attained the patience of the non-arising of phenomena, and who were endowed with hundreds of thousands of excellent qualities.

At that time the Blessed One arose from his meditative equipoise at the close of the afternoon and, before long, was teaching the Dharma to the many hundreds of thousands assembled around him, looking out over them as they surrounded him. He taught the holy life — virtuous in the beginning, virtuous in the middle, virtuous in the end — of good meaning and good words, unmixed, perfectly complete, perfectly pure, and perfectly clear.

At that time the bodhisattva, the great being Sublime Gnosis was gathered there in that very assembly and was seated. Then the bodhisattva, the great being Sublime Gnosis rose from his seat, arranged his upper robe over one shoulder, placed the knee of his right leg upon the ground, bowed with his palms joined toward the Blessed One in the direction where the Blessed One was, and addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"If the Blessed One would grant me the occasion to ask and to receive a prophecy in response to my asking, I would put to the Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, several questions on my part."

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva, the great being Sublime Gnosis as follows: "Son of good family, ask the Tathāgata whatever you wish, and I will satisfy your mind by prophesying the very answers to what you have asked."

When the Blessed One had so spoken, the bodhisattva, the great being Sublime Gnosis addressed the Blessed One thus: "Venerable Blessed One, with regard to the skillful means of the bodhisattvas, the great beings — what is called 'skillful means' — what exactly is that skillful means? Venerable Blessed One, in what manner is a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in skillful means?"

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva, the great being Sublime Gnosis as follows: "Excellent! Excellent! Son of good family, you are

asking this for the benefit of the many, for the happiness of the many, out of compassion for the world, for the welfare, benefit, and happiness of the great multitude of gods and humans — and in order to uphold the understanding of the bodhisattvas, the great beings of the present and the future, to bring all the qualities of a buddha to perfect completion, and —" and at this point the passage continues.

— and in order to take up and preserve the noble Dharma of the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, who are present in this very age. Son of good family, it is indeed excellent of you to think of asking the Tathāgata about the skillful means of the bodhisattvas. Therefore, son of good family, listen well and take it thoroughly to heart in the proper way, for I shall explain to you the skillful means of the bodhisattvas, the great beings."

The bodhisattva, the great being Sublime Gnosis replied to the Blessed One, "So be it, Blessed One," and listened attentively to the Blessed One. The Blessed One then spoke to him as follows.

"Son of good family, here is a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in skillful means: even a single morsel of food he gives to all sentient beings. Why is that? Because a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in skillful means, whenever he gives even a single morsel of food — even when he has taken birth in an animal existence — gives it with a mind imbued with omniscience, and dedicates that root of virtue so that all sentient beings may bring the qualities of a buddha to perfect completion. It is for these two reasons that he dedicates it to all sentient beings: the mind of omniscience and the very skill in dedication. Son of good family, that is the skillful means of the bodhisattva, the great being.

Furthermore, son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in skillful means rejoices in the roots of virtue that others have gathered and accumulated. And having rejoiced, he releases and dedicates those roots of virtue to all sentient beings. Through those roots of virtue dedicated to omniscience, he surpasses all givers and donors who give without the awakening mind, and surpasses all recipients as well. Son of good family, that too is the skillful means of the bodhisattva, the great being.

Furthermore, son of good family, a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in skillful means: whatever flowering trees and fragrant trees, whatever flowers, garlands, incense, powders, and unguents exist in all ten directions that no one has claimed as their own and no one has taken up — all of these he

mentally gathers and collects, and offers them to all the buddhas, and dedicates that root of virtue to all sentient beings, and having dedicated it, further dedicates it to omniscience. And whatever flowering trees and fragrant trees, whatever flowers, garlands, incense, powders, and unguents in all ten directions have been claimed and taken up — the scent borne on the wind from all of these as well, the bodhisattva skilled in skillful means offers to all the buddhas, and that root of virtue he dedicates to omniscience, so that both himself and all sentient beings may bring omniscience to perfect completion.

Through those roots of virtue dedicated to omniscience, one will attain immeasurable aggregates of moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the wisdom of the vision of liberation. Son of good family, that too is the skillful means of the bodhisattva, the great being."

"Son of good family, furthermore, the skillful means of the bodhisattva, the great being, is this: however many sentient beings throughout world-systems in the ten directions there may be who experience the sensation of suffering, the bodhisattva skilled in skillful means gathers together all those sensations of suffering of those sentient beings and takes them upon himself, thinking, 'May all these sensations of suffering of those sentient beings descend upon my own body, and may those sentient beings be happy.' In this way he also dons the armor. And however many sentient beings throughout all the world-systems of the ten directions there may be who experience the sensation of happiness, the bodhisattva skilled in skillful means fully gathers those together and rejoices in them. Having so rejoiced, with a mind aimed at omniscience he dedicates everything to omniscience itself, in order that all the suffering of all sentient beings may be utterly pacified. Through that root of virtue he will attain all the provisions of happiness of all the buddhas. Son of good family, that too is the skillful means of the bodhisattva, the great being.

Son of good family, furthermore, the skillful means of the bodhisattva, the great being, is this: he bows down before a single Tathāgata, shows him respect, takes him as his teacher, paints his image, makes offerings to him, and renders him homage. Having done so, he reflects in the following way: 'The buddhas, the Blessed Ones, have all issued forth from a single dharmadhātu, share a single moral discipline, a single meditative absorption, a single wisdom, a single liberation, and a single wisdom of the vision of liberation; they share a single gnosis and a single knowledge.' He reflects in this way, and then he comes to understand thus: 'By bowing before a single Tathāgata, showing him respect, taking him as teacher, painting his image,

making offerings to him, and rendering him homage, I have thereby bowed before all Tathāgatas, shown them all respect, taken them all as teacher, painted the images of them all, made offerings to them all, and rendered homage to them all.' The bodhisattva skilled in skillful means fully embraces in mind all the offerings that will be made to all the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, of the ten directions, and dedicates them all to omniscience. Son of good family, that too is the skillful means of the bodhisattva, the great being.

Son of good family, furthermore, the skillful means of the bodhisattva, the great being, is this: whenever his mind becomes dull, he does not disparage himself or become discouraged, but instead he engages with even a single four-line verse. And he reflects in this way: 'The meaning of this single four-line verse is the meaning of the entirety of all that belongs to the sacred scriptures.' Having learned even one such four-line verse by heart, and with a mind free of discouragement, he arouses great compassion. Without any desire for gain, honor, or fame, he teaches that four-line verse in full and correctly to the many people in villages, towns, hamlets, districts, and royal courts around about. And he also makes this aspiration:"

"May all sentient beings who come to hear this four-line verse of mine be established with certainty in unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening." And having made that aspiration, he also offers it to them.

Because that root of virtue is held within skillful means, all sentient beings will come to have much learning, like Ānanda himself, and they will also attain the very eloquence of a buddha. That noble son, too, is one skilled in the means of a bodhisattva, a great being.

Moreover, noble son, another way in which a bodhisattva, a great being, is skilled in means is this: if he should find himself impoverished, even amid a hundred roads, he takes on the work of others, and with whatever small amount of food and provisions he thereby receives, he gives it — without any discouragement of mind — to the Saṅgha or to an individual person. And having given, he reflects in this way: "The Blessed One has taught that when one gives with a great mind, the giving itself becomes great. Therefore this object of mine that is to be given is meager, yet because it is given with the mind of omniscience it will become immeasurable." He reflects on it just so. With that mind of omniscience become boundless, he gives that small amount of food and provisions, and he dedicates the roots of virtue entirely, thinking: "By this root of virtue, may I myself and all sentient beings — just as the

Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha Śākyamuni — achieve in like manner the supreme excellent mark of the perfume of the major marks of a great being and attain the jewel in the hand." And having dedicated all those roots of virtue to omniscience, he comes to overshadow the merit-substance arising from the giving of sentient beings who lack the awakening mind; the supreme excellent mark of the perfume of the major marks of a great being is also accomplished; and the jewel in the hand is also accomplished. Noble son, that too is a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in means.

Furthermore, noble son, another way in which a bodhisattva, a great being, is skilled in means is this: even if he should dwell together with śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and with those who follow the vehicle of the śrāvakas and those who follow the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas, he does not take delight in them. And if a bodhisattva skilled in means sees that those śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas receive more honor and offerings than he does, and that it is not so for himself, he reflects on this through two reasons. What are the two? He reflects to himself: "Those who issue forth from bodhisattvas are the blessed buddhas; and those who issue forth from the blessed buddhas are the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas." And he further reflects in this way: "Though they receive more honor and offerings, nonetheless I myself am in this very matter most supreme, most exalted, while they are not. They are enjoying what belongs to my father's treasure-heap, and therefore I will neither take delight in them nor envy them." He reflects just so. And because he arouses the mind of awakening with such elevated intention, he will not be puffed up when services are rendered to the Tathāgata, nor will he be downcast when they are not, and he will attain attachment to and abandonment of anger in the likeness of one who holds equanimity equally toward all sentient beings. Noble son, that too is a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in means.

Noble son, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in means, perfects all six perfections through the single act of giving. How does he perfect them all? Here, a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in means, whenever he sees a beggar, fixes his mind on omniscience, cuts through the thought of miserliness, cultivates great generosity, and arouses the intention "I shall give." That is his perfection of generosity.

He takes up proper moral discipline, gives to those who are endowed with moral discipline, and establishes in moral discipline those sentient beings who have broken it; and having given, he establishes them in unsurpassed, perfect,

complete awakening. That is his perfection of moral discipline.

He gives with a mind of loving-kindness, a mind of beneficence, an unmixed mind, an unagitated mind, a mind free from laziness, a mind without turbidity, and an even mind. That is his perfection of patience.

He earnestly pursues and strives with full respect in regard to food, drink, taste, and flavour; he serves with body and serves with mind; he rises, goes forth, and comes forward. That is his perfection of diligence.

In what he has given he maintains one-pointedness of mind, joy, mental ease, an intention of supreme delight, and the absence of distraction. That is his perfection of meditative concentration.

Having given, he turns rightly toward the nature of reality, investigating: "Who gave? To whom was it given? What was given? Who will experience its karmic maturation?" Having turned thus rightly toward the nature of reality, and having searched in that way, he finds no dharma whatsoever that is the giver, the recipient, the thing given, or the one who experiences its karmic maturation. That is his perfection of wisdom.

Noble son, it is thus that a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in means, perfects all six perfections through the single act of giving.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being, Supreme Wisdom, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, it is indeed wondrous that a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in means, through that very act of giving both fully holds sentient beings back from saṃsāra and fully encompasses all the qualities of a buddha. That skillful means of bodhisattvas, great beings, skilled in means, is truly marvellous."

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, it is just so. It is exactly as you have said. A bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in means, through skillful means and through the perfection of skillful means, makes even a small gift great, and makes what is great immeasurable and incalculable."

Then the Blessed One again spoke to the bodhisattva, the great being, Supreme Wisdom, with these words: "Noble son, furthermore, a bodhisattva, a great being, skilled in means — even if he has committed a fault under the influence of an evil companion along the way, one in a hundred, or through a completely bewildered mind — he trains himself in this way: 'If I, through the aggregates, elements, and

"would attain nirvāṇa through these very aggregates, elements, and sense bases, then I would have to torment myself greatly — and so I shall put on this armor: I will not let my mind waver, I will not be afraid, I will not be terrified, I will not torment myself over continuing to wander in saṃsāra until the very end of the furthest future in order to bring sentient beings to full maturity. However I wander in saṃsāra, in just that way I shall ripen sentient beings. I shall also confess this fault in accordance with the Dharma and ensure that from this point forward no such fault arises again. And I shall teach the Dharma in order to free all sentient beings from their faults." In this way he puts on that armor.

Noble son, if one takes up close examination, then even if a bodhisattva who has gone forth has committed all four root faults, if, being skilled in means, he purifies them, then, noble son, I declare that such a bodhisattva is without fault.

When this was said, the bodhisattva, the great being, Supreme Wisdom, spoke these words to the Blessed One: "Venerable Blessed One, how is it that a bodhisattva possesses a fault?"

The Blessed One declared: "Noble son, when a bodhisattva is training in the training of individual liberation, even if for a hundred thousand eons he subsists on roots and fruits, and bears with patience all the praise and blame that any sentient being may utter, still, if he then abides in a way of thinking that belongs to śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas, noble son, that is called a bodhisattva's grave root fault. Noble son, take this as an example: just as a person following the vehicle of the hearers who has committed a root fault no longer has the fortune to pass into nirvāṇa through those very aggregates, elements, and sense bases, so too, as long as a bodhisattva has not confessed and abandoned such thoughts oriented toward śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, he has no fortune to fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, complete, and perfect awakening, and no fortune to attain the state of a buddha — and that is impossible."

Then the venerable Ānanda spoke these words to the Blessed One: "Venerable Blessed One, the Tathāgata is the Teacher of all sentient beings; there is nothing whatsoever that he does not know, does not see, does not comprehend, or does not make directly manifest. Yet the Tathāgata has declared that when a monk is seen to have committed a fault, it should not be concealed, but should be disclosed either to other practitioners of pure

conduct or in the presence of the Tathāgata himself. Venerable Blessed One, when I was going on alms rounds through the great city of Śrāvastī in order, I saw in another city a bodhisattva named Samūha-pramukhārāja seated upon a throne together with a woman. I report this to the Blessed One with a mind of loving-kindness and without any fault of intention."

Scarcely had the venerable Ānanda finished speaking these words than this great earth shook and trembled in six ways. And at that very moment, the bodhisattva Samūha-pramukhārāja rose up into the sky in the presence of the Blessed One to a height of about seven tāla trees, and sitting there in the air, spoke these words to the venerable Ānanda: "Venerable Ānanda, what do you think of this?"

"Do you think that one who has transgressive qualities can remain suspended in the sky?" Ānanda replied: "Son of good family, that is not possible." The bodhisattva Samūha-pramukhārāja then said: "Venerable Ānanda, yet in the presence of this manifest Tathāgata, go ahead and ask the bodhisattva how he has transgressive qualities."

At that, the venerable Ānanda became ashamed, and touching his head to the feet of the Blessed One, he addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Reverend Blessed One, whatever fault it was that I spoke of in speaking at length of such a fault in this great lord, recognizing it as a fault — if I have gone so far as to recognize it as a fault — then, reverend Blessed One, let the Blessed One fully acknowledge whatever confession of my fault I now confess."

The Blessed One then said these words to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, do not give rise to the perception of fault toward noble persons who have genuinely entered the Great Vehicle. Ānanda, consider this example: just as a person of the śrāvaka vehicle who dwells alone, without companion, abiding in calm abiding, encounters no obstacle in realizing the exhaustion of defilements directly — so too, Ānanda, you should understand that a great bodhisattva skilled in skillful means, possessed of a mind oriented toward omniscience, who sits within a noble circle of women and engages in joy, play, and delight, creates no interruption whatsoever on the path to omniscience. And why is this? Ānanda, a great bodhisattva skilled in skillful means is the Three Jewels. And what are the three? The Jewel of the Buddha, the Jewel of the Dharma, and the Jewel of the Saṅgha — because he does not grasp at any retinue not yet directed toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

"Ānanda, whenever you see a son or daughter of good family of the bodhisattva vehicle who does not depart from a mind oriented toward omniscience and who engages in play, joy, and delight through the five qualities of sensory pleasure, you should know, Ānanda, that such a noble person abides endowed with the five faculties of a Tathāgata.

"Ānanda, and now listen to why the bodhisattva Samūha-pramukhārāja came to be seated together with a woman on a single throne. Ānanda, that woman, in a past time, over five hundred lifetimes, had been the wife of the bodhisattva Samūha-pramukhārāja. Through that same improper conduct of former times she had become intensely attached in mind to that son of good family. Yet when she saw the splendor, the majesty, and the power of moral discipline of that bodhisattva Samūha-pramukhārāja, she was unable to utter any words of base passion. And while sitting alone in seclusion, a thought arose in her mind: 'If the bodhisattva Samūha-pramukhārāja were to sit with me together upon a single throne, then I too would generate the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.'

"Then the bodhisattva Samūha-pramukhārāja, having known through his own mind the full range of thoughts in that woman's mind, on that very night — as it passed and the hour of early morning came — donned his lower robe and outer Dharma robe, took up his alms bowl, and set out for alms in the great city of Śrāvastī."

As he was walking through the great city of Śrāvastī for alms, he arrived at that very place — the home of that woman — and entered within. There, through the Dharma-door of the principle that the inner earth element and the outer earth element are, in their nature, one and the same, he took hold of the woman's right hand with a mind equal to the earth, and settled her upon a single throne with him. The moment they were seated, he spoke these verses:

A buddha does not praise desire —
that is the domain of the childish.

If one abandons craving and attachment to desire,
one becomes a supreme being, a buddha.

"Ānanda, upon hearing those verses the woman felt joy and supreme joy arise. She descended from the throne, prostrated at the feet of the bodhisattva Samūha-pramukhārāja, and at that moment spoke these words in verse:

Whatever desires the buddhas have censured
I will henceforth no longer pursue.

Having abandoned craving and attachment to desire,
may I accomplish the goal of becoming a supreme being, a buddha.
Whatever fault was conceived by my own mind —
that transgression I confess to you.
For the sake of medicine for all living beings,
I now give rise to the aspiration for awakening.

"Ānanda, in this way the bodhisattva Samūha-pramukhārāja, through his mastery of skillful means, rightly showed that woman unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; rightly praised and encouraged her; rightly established her in it; and then, having firmly settled her in it, rose from his seat and departed.

"Ānanda, consider the extraordinary quality of her supreme aspiration. Ānanda, from the time that woman passed away from this life and transformed out of a woman's body, after nine hundred and ninety-nine countless aeons had elapsed, she will appear in this world as a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly complete buddha named 'Free from All Arising.' And in that buddha-field which she will attain upon awakening, it has been prophesied that not a single sentient being will arise there possessed of a mind caught up in unwholesome arising.

"Ānanda, you should understand from this that a bodhisattva does not grasp at whatever retinue or following would become a cause of their falling into error.

"Then the bodhisattva Samūha-pramukhārāja descended from the sky and, bowing his head at the feet of the Blessed One, addressed the Blessed One in these words: 'Venerable Blessed One, it is proper for a bodhisattva to abide in skillful means and great compassion. Venerable Blessed One, as for this matter: I think to myself that if a bodhisattva were to commit such a transgression for the sake of genuinely planting a root of virtue in even one sentient being, and if owing to such a transgression as has here occurred he were to burn in the great hells for a hundred thousand aeons, still, Venerable Blessed One, the bodhisattva should willingly accept that transgression and that suffering of the great hells — but should not abandon the roots of virtue of even that one sentient being. This is what I think.'

"Then the Blessed One, expressing approval to the bodhisattva Samūha-pramukhārāja, spoke: 'Excellent! Excellent, noble one! A bodhisattva

endowed with such great compassion as this neither comes to possess the nature of fault, nor does he abandon all wrongdoing. Why is that? Because I know this through direct cognition. In a past time, across incalculable aeons — beyond incalculable, vast, immeasurable, inconceivable, supremely beyond supreme — there appeared, at that time and in that age, a brahmin youth named Kārma."

For forty-two thousand years he practiced the holy life in forest groves. When those forty-two thousand years had passed, he entered the palace called Suprabhava in a great city. Upon entering that great city, a merchant's daughter saw the brahmin youth Karma, who was handsome, beautiful, and lovely to behold. Her mind wholly ensnared by desire for sensual pleasures, she ran up before that brahmin youth and touched his feet.

Then, noble son, from that place the brahmin youth Karma said to that girl: "Sister, what do you want?" She said to him: "Brahmin youth, I desire you." He said to her: "Sister, I do not seek after sensual pleasures. I practice the holy life." She said to him: "Brahmin youth, if you will not keep company with me, I shall take my own life."

Then the brahmin youth Karma thought to himself: "I have practiced the holy life for forty-two thousand years, and now to break my vow of celibacy today — this is not in keeping with my conduct." He therefore pushed the girl away by force and walked seven paces from her. But as he stood at that seventh step, compassion arose in him, and he thought: "Even if I break my vow of celibacy and must go to the hell realms for it, I shall bear whatever suffering I experience there in the hell realms, so long as this girl may be happy and not be brought to her death. I must not let that be." Noble son, the brahmin youth Karma then turned back from that place, took that girl by his right hand, and said to her: "Good woman, come — I shall do as you wish."

Then the brahmin youth Karma dwelt in her home for twelve years. Thereafter he emerged once again and, having cultivated the four divine abodes (brahmaviharas), he passed from that life and was born in the brahma world.

Noble son, do not let any doubt or uncertainty arise in your mind that the one who at that time and in that age was known as the brahmin youth Karma was someone other than myself. Why is that? I myself was the one who at that time and in that age was known as the brahmin youth Karma. And the daughter of Śākyā (Sāktā), Sātvamā, was at that time and in that age the merchant's daughter.

Noble son, by the mere act of arousing a mind endowed with great compassion — even one that led to a brief engagement in sensual pleasures — I came to traverse and abandon tens of thousands of aeons of wandering in cyclic existence. Noble son, consider that even a karmic act that would lead other sentient beings to the hell realms will, for a bodhisattva skilled in skillful means, lead instead to birth in the brahma world.

Then the Blessed One spoke further to the great bodhisattva Jñānottama: "Noble son, if the monks Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana had been skilled in skillful means, then even the monk Kokālika would not have gone to the hell realms. Why is that? Noble son, through my direct knowledge (abhijñā): in a past time there appeared, in the scriptural collection of the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and fully awakened buddha called Saṃsāravibhaṅga, a Dharma-preacher named the monk Vimāla. He dwelt in a cave in a forest hermitage."

Not very far from there, some five hundred sages also dwelt. At that time, out of season, great clouds gathered and a tremendous rain fell. Two women who were on the road between villages, seeking shelter from that rain, entered the cave where the monk Vimāla was dwelling. When they came back out of the cave, those approximately five hundred sages saw the two women emerging from the monk Vimāla's cave. Having seen this, those five hundred sages thought to themselves: "Alas! This monk Vimāla is wicked, one who desires and engages in unchaste conduct." And so thoughts of hostility and aversion arose in them.

Then the monk Vimāla, knowing with his mind the full range of those five hundred sages' thoughts, at that very moment rose up into the sky above to a height of about seven palm trees and remained there. When those sages saw this, they thought to themselves: "According to our own treatises, one who engages in unchaste conduct cannot rise up and remain in the sky above." And so, in that very instant, all five hundred sages prostrated to the monk Vimāla with their five limbs touching the ground and confessed their wrongdoing as a wrongdoing.

Noble son, had the monk Vimāla at that moment not risen up and remained in the sky above, those five hundred sages would each, in their very bodies, have fallen into the great hells. Noble son, what do you think? If doubt and uncertainty arise in you, thinking that the one called the monk Vimāla at that time and on that occasion was someone else, you should not view it that way.

Why is that? The bodhisattva Maitreya (Loving-kindness) was, at that time and on that occasion, that very one called the monk Vimāla.

Noble son, by that same token you should understand it thus: had the monks Śāriputra and Maudgalyāyana at that time risen up and remained in the sky above, the monk Kokālika likewise would not have gone to the hell realms.

Noble son, by that same token you should also understand it thus: the domain into which a bodhisattva skilled in skillful means enters through gnosis is not accessible to any śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha whatsoever.

Noble son, consider this example: a courtesan who knows and has mastered sixty-four arts — for the sake of obtaining wealth, she gives herself completely to another person and shows him delight, and for as long as she has not accomplished every aim she seeks from that person, she continues to act in that very manner, withholding none of her resources from him. But once her aim has been accomplished, she abandons him, no longer looking at him or thinking of him, and not so much as a single thought of regret toward him in that regard arises in her. In just the same way, noble son, the bodhisattva skilled in skillful means, knowing that through these very skillful means these sentient beings are to be brought to full maturation, draws near to those sentient beings in accordance with their aspirations and withholds none of his resources from them. He gives himself completely out of delight in the virtue of those sentient beings — not out of delight in the resources themselves. And when at last these sentient beings have made roots of virtue —

— and he knows that they will not be able to squander those roots afterward — then from that point on he turns his gaze away from every pleasure and amusement of the desire realm and departs, no longer dwelling in a mind connected with those things.

Noble son, consider this analogy: seeds that have been thoroughly scorched by fire lose their color entirely and have no capacity to sprout. In just the same way, noble son, when the afflictions of the bodhisattva are thoroughly scorched by emptiness, signlessness, wishlessness, selflessness, and the Perfection of Wisdom, then even though he may engage fully in every pleasure of the desire realm, he does not take up the defilements that lead to a downfall, nor does he fade from the complexion of buddhahood.

Noble son, consider this analogy: the honeybee, born into an animal existence, gathers nectar from all manner of flowers and tastes their sweetness, yet it does not cultivate a perception of permanence toward any of them, does not

generate craving for the place, and does not strip the flowers of their fragrance, petals, stems, or blooms. In just the same way, noble son, the bodhisattva skilled in skillful means, though he enjoys every pleasure and amusement in order to bring sentient beings to full maturation, does not cultivate a perception of permanence toward those things, does not generate craving for the place, and acts so that neither he himself nor others are harmed.

Noble son, consider this analogy: a fisherman thoroughly trained in his craft ties bait to a single line and casts it into a great lake. That single, well-guarded line: whenever he desires, he draws the bait back out of the great lake. In just the same way, noble son, the bodhisattva skilled in skillful means, having thoroughly cultivated emptiness, signlessness, wishlessness, selflessness, and the Perfection of Wisdom, secures the mind of omniscience as his anchor, and then plunges into the great swamp of desire. Yet by means of that mind of omniscience, well guarded, whenever he wishes he abandons the desire realm and takes birth in the Brahmā world.

Noble son, consider this analogy: a man who holds knowledge-mantras and secret mantras may be seized by the king's men and bound with a fivefold rope of fetters, yet whenever he wishes to leave, by arousing the power of his knowledge-mantras and secret mantras in a single effort, he cuts through all those bonds and goes wherever he desires. In just the same way, noble son, the bodhisattva skilled in skillful means, in order to bring sentient beings to full maturation, may experience the pleasures of the five sense qualities of desire and dwell in their company, yet whenever he wishes, by a single effort — arousing the power of the wisdom-mantra and the secret mantra, and keeping the mind of omniscience well guarded — he cuts through all the bonds of the five sense qualities of desire, and then, passing from that life, takes birth in the Brahmā world.

Noble son, consider this analogy: a well-trained surgeon takes up a sharp sword wrapped in cloth bandaging and thereby liberates many who are in distress. Now, those sentient beings who are unskilled and do not know the surgeon's art look upon that surgeon with pity and generate a perception of contempt, saying words such as these: "He has no bow, no sword, no shaft —"

"He has no retinue either, and so he cannot liberate these people in distress. If he cannot even liberate himself, how much less can he liberate all who are in distress, defeat the band of robbers, and so forth? Since there is no basis for it,

this man will die by means that are contrary to what is fitting." Such words they might say.

Then that master surgeon enters a remote wilderness, and when a band of robbers has gathered there, he takes up his bow and arrows, dons hard armor, draws that weapon, and shoots at the robbers. By this he separates all those robbers from their lives, and then takes the weapon back into his hand.

In just the same way, noble son, a bodhisattva who is skilled in means, in order to bring sentient beings to full maturation, takes up well the weapon of the Perfection of Wisdom, and through his skill in means he engages in delight, play, and pleasurable sport by means of the five sense qualities of desire. At that time, those who follow the śrāvaka vehicle and have not understood within themselves that knowledge of his skill in means — when they see him, they generate lack of faith toward him and generate compassion, and they say these words: "This one who dwells in a state of heedlessness cannot liberate even himself, so how much less could he liberate all sentient beings? How could he possibly defeat the armies of Māra? Since there is no basis for it, this man will die by means that are contrary to what is fitting." This too they might say.

Yet that bodhisattva who is skilled in means and is thoroughly possessed of wisdom — at whatever time he so wishes, with that weapon of wisdom he cuts through and completely severs the entire net of afflictions, and together with wisdom he goes on to the buddha-field, utterly and completely pure, free of women and free of union.

When these words had been spoken, the bodhisattva mahāsattva named Ānandakara went into the great city of Śrāvastī to gather alms. As he was wandering for alms in the great city of Śrāvastī, he went to the home of a merchant. That merchant had a young daughter named Śrīguṇottamā, a mere child, who was sitting on the upper floor of the fine house. She heard the voice of that monk, took up the alms bowl, and went to where the bodhisattva Ānandakara was.

Then, the very moment Śrīguṇottamā saw the bodhisattva Ānandakara, her mind became completely bound by attachment, and she took hold of the marks of his minor features, his voice and sounds, and his complexion. Her mind was wholly wound about by attachment, her mind wholly aroused by attachment, her mind wholly struck through by attachment, her mind wholly consumed by attachment — scorched by it, her body broke into a sweat, and

as she stood there she died at that very moment.

The bodhisattva Ānandakara, for his part, upon seeing the girl Śrīguṇottamā, had a conceptual thought of an inappropriate mental engagement arise in him — that is, a mind accompanied by attachment arose — yet after just a moment, this recollection arose in him: "Whatever phenomenon there is toward which attachment arises — what is that phenomenon? Is the eye attached to the eye? The eye itself is not attached — it is without movement, without agency, without intentionality, compounded, of seven successive layers, a ball of flesh. The eye, being empty by nature, does not intend and does not feel. The ear, the nose, the tongue, the body, the mind, the skin, the color, the flesh — these too are the same. If one examines separately from the soles of the feet up to the crown of the head, what is there within or without toward which attachment could arise?"

nor any phenomenon toward which aversion or delusion might arise. Finding nothing to apprehend in that way, he became free of the mind of attachment. And through that freedom, examining all phenomena precisely as they are by means of the mind itself, he understood that all phenomena are unborn, and thereby attained patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena (anutpattikadharmakṣānti).

The very joy and supreme joy of that attainment lifted him aloft into the sky above to the height of seven tāla trees. He then circled the great city of Śrāvastī seven times, and from that same sky directed himself toward where Prince Jeta's Grove was, and toward where the Blessed One was, and went there.

Second Fascicle.

The Blessed One beheld the great bodhisattva Ānandakara descending from the sky above, free of all clinging, like the king of geese. Having beheld this, the Blessed One addressed the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, do you see the great bodhisattva Ānandakara descending from the sky above, free of all clinging, like the king of geese?"

The venerable Ānanda replied: "Blessed One, I see him."

The Blessed One then declared: "Ānanda, this great bodhisattva Ānandakara, relying upon the mind of attachment and thoroughly searching through all phenomena, tamed the host of māras and turned the wheel of Dharma excellently.

"Thereafter, the daughter Śrīvātī passed away at the time of her death, abandoned her female body, was reborn in a heavenly world, and obtained a body equal in fortune to the gods of the Thirty-Three. Immediately upon her birth there appeared for her a celestial palace twelve leagues in measure, fashioned from the seven precious substances, and forty-four thousand divine maidens who waited upon her in attendance and service.

"At that very moment she reflected: 'Through what karma have I accumulated deeds that have caused me to be born here?' And she thought: 'I was the daughter of a merchant in the great city of Śrāvastī. There, I gazed upon the great bodhisattva Ānandakara with a mind of total attachment, and with a mind thoroughly bound by sensual desire, I died at the time of my death, abandoned my female body, and have now obtained this birth, along with immeasurable wealth and riches such as these.' With that, the recollective awareness of her former karma arose in her.

"The divine youth then thought: 'If even the ripening of attachment can produce results such as these, then how much more need be said of the fact that I have made prostrations to and served the great bodhisattva Ānandakara with a mind of faith? It is not fitting for me, and it is improper, to dwell in a state of carelessness, spending my time in sensual pleasures, play, and amusement. I must go without delay to where the Blessed One is and where the great bodhisattva Ānandakara is.'

"And so that divine youth, together with a retinue of five hundred, took divine flowers, incense, garlands, and perfumed unguents, and went to where the Blessed One was and where the great bodhisattva Ānandakara was. Illuminating the Jeta Grove with an exceedingly brilliant and magnificent radiance of surpassing color, they made offerings to the Blessed One with those divine flowers, incense, garlands, and perfumed unguents, and then prostrated with their heads at the feet of the Blessed One."

They also prostrated with their heads at the feet of the great bodhisattva Ānandakara and all the bodhisattvas and the assembly of monks. Then, circumambulating the Blessed One seven times, they joined their palms together before the Blessed One's presence and at that time offered these verses:

The buddhas, supreme among humans, are inconceivable.

Those who have entered the highest awakening are inconceivable.

The Dharma of the Sugatas is likewise inconceivable.

The conduct of the greatly renowned is inconceivable.

Formerly in Śrāvastī I took birth as a girl,
daughter of a merchant, called Śrī-vara-uttamā.

Beautiful, and poor at first,
I went to rest in my parents' lap, deeply beloved.

He who was not reviled as a son of the buddhas,
the great and powerful one called Ānandakara —
when he wandered through Śrāvastī on his alms round,
he came to my father's home.

Having heard his sweet and pleasing voice,
we took up our alms bowl with minds full of feeling,
and went to where that son of the Tathāgata,
the great and powerful Ānandakara, might be found.

The moment I saw him, attachment arose in me
in a manner that was improper and unfitting.
I thought: if I do not meet him as I hope,
I will take no heed of my life — it will be time to die.

Tormented utterly by improper desire for him,
as I was about to speak words to him
and had just reached out to offer him alms —
I fainted and collapsed, standing there, in a swoon.

Blessed One, at the very moment of my dying,
in that same instant I abandoned the female body,
and passing away was reborn in a heavenly realm,
and I obtained this very radiant male birth.

A magnificent celestial palace, beautiful
and lovely to behold, adorned with many kinds of jewels, arose complete.
And my attendants — divine maidens —
came to be a full fourteen thousand.

The good mind that arose in me:
from what action did such ripening come?
Recalling it, I thought to myself:
such is the ripening of a mind accompanied by attachment.

Toward Ānandakara — joyful, radiant, and wise —
because I looked with a mind of attachment,
through that good ripening of that action,
I have obtained such majesty, power, and strength.

If the ripening of a mind accompanied by attachment is thus,
then what need is there to speak of one who makes actual offerings to him?
One into whom the knowledge of the Sugatas will enter —
that one is not on the ground of a śrāvaka or pratyekabuddha.

Before the Tathāgata's presence I make this pledge:
to accomplish the supreme buddha-wisdom in full,
to practice for as many kalpas as there are grains of sand in the Ganges —
this vow of mine I shall not abandon.

I shall honor the holy spiritual friend Ānandakara
with the highest Dharma offering.
No one other than those seeking awakening
will be fit to guide and make offerings to this one.

Whatever women contemplate me with a mind of attachment,
may they all, having transformed the female body,
attain fearless male birth
and practice the highest and holy conduct of awakening.

When her body was seen to have fainted and fallen,
Śrī-vara-uttamā's parents lamented and wept,
thinking that this monk had cast a spell on her,
and weeping they spoke ill of the renunciants.

By the power of the Buddha that divine youth went
and spoke these words to her parents:

Do not be angry and hostile toward the renunciant.
Do not bring long suffering upon yourselves.
The girl Śrī-vara-uttamā who has passed away
has been reborn with equal fortune in the Heaven of the Thirty-Three.
She has abandoned the female body
and become a radiant divine son.

Before the Sugata, now today,
may the fault of your wrathful mind be healed.
Other than the buddhas, supreme among humans,

there is no other refuge and ally for sentient beings.

Urged on well by that fearless one —

Upon hearing the word "buddha," both parents, together with a gathering of their relatives, went before Śākyamuni and, bowing their heads at the feet of the supreme among men, confessed the fault of their wrathful minds. They then addressed the Tathāgata with reverence, making this request to the Sugata, the self-arisen one:

How may the Guide be honored? How is the Dharma to be honored, and how the Saṅgha? Please grant us an answer to this question. Having heard it, we will abide by it and do nothing else.

The Victor, knowing their intent, the Protector of the World, declared these words:

Whoever wishes to make offerings to all the buddhas, let that one steadfastly arouse the awakening mind. The father and mother and relatives of the girl — no fewer than five hundred in all — upon hearing the words of that foremost being, steadfastly aroused the mind set on awakening.

The Victor then spoke to Ānanda:

Ānanda, listen now to what I say. The conduct of bodhisattvas is immeasurable, and so too is their mastery of wisdom and skillful means. He who rejoices in them makes aspiration again and again. Those women who, through minds of attachment, fixed thoughts on me as a woman's body — may they swiftly be reborn as fearless men. Not one woman, not two, not three, but many women — by the tens of millions and thousands of millions — those who came to be attached to the one who causes joy, all of them, upon dying and being reborn, were reborn thus. Ānanda, see the quality of being reborn: the very attachment through which other sentient beings would go to a mind-hell — through that, the courageous ones go to the higher realms. The divine son who made offerings to me and, with reverence, entered upon the supreme awakening — he, having made offerings to countless buddhas, will become a Victor named Sudarśana, Beautiful to Behold. The five hundred who entered upon awakening will arise as supreme among men. Who would not honor the Protector of the World, faith in whom brings immeasurable happiness? If even those with afflictions receive happiness from him, what need is there to speak of those who honor him? Who would generate aversion toward bodhisattvas

who are like a great and renowned king of medicine?

Then the venerable Ānanda said this to the Blessed One:

Venerable Blessed One, to take an example: if any being who possesses a thoroughly hostile mind, or a clear and serene mind, or a mind of attachment, or a mind that obstructs the Dharma, were to approach the king of mountains, Mount Meru, all of them would uniformly become the same golden hue. In just the same way, Venerable Blessed One, if any being who possesses a thoroughly hostile mind, or a serene mind, or a mind of attachment, or a mind that obstructs the Dharma, were to approach the bodhisattvas, all of their minds would become one in the hue of omniscient mind. Therefore, Venerable Blessed One, from this day forward I shall regard all bodhisattvas as equal to Mount Meru, king of mountains.

Venerable Blessed One, to take another example: there exists a great species of medicinal plant called Sudarśana, Beautiful to Behold. If any beings — whether possessed of a thoroughly hostile mind or a serene and clear mind — who are afflicted by various diseases of poison were to behold it, all their diseases of poison would be completely pacified. In just the same way, Venerable Blessed One, when those sentient beings who possess either a thoroughly hostile mind or a clear and serene mind approach the bodhisattvas, all of their afflictions of attachment, aversion, delusion, and mental affliction will likewise be completely pacified.

Then the Blessed One spoke to Venerable Ānanda, affirming exactly what had been said: "Excellent! Excellent!" he declared.

Then Venerable Mahākāśyapa addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, it is a wonder of the great bodhisattvas that, for the sake of sentient beings and out of loving concern for them, they dwell established in the abiding of the peaceful meditative absorption of calm, while yet remaining present even in the desire realm — and that they also abide in the qualities of emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness, free from any striving toward further becoming, and yet do not come into contact with the qualities of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and continuously arouse great compassion, and enter into the mind of omniscience. That, Venerable Blessed One, is the wonder of the great bodhisattvas. That is the supreme wonder of the Sugata. Venerable Blessed One, those great bodhisattvas who guard against all forms of attachment, and yet engage with attachment to forms, sounds, scents, tastes, and tangible objects, while never becoming attached to

any of these — they dwell in the inconceivable skillful means. Venerable Blessed One, with the great bodhisattvas as my subject, I feel confident to venture some analogies. Sugata, I feel confident to do so."

The Blessed One declared: "Kāśyapa, be confident and speak."

Venerable Mahākāśyapa then submitted: "Venerable Blessed One, consider this analogy: suppose there were a great wilderness enclosure, and that great wilderness enclosure had a fence equal in height to the peak of existence, and within that great wilderness enclosure many hundreds of thousands of living creatures had entered, and that great wilderness enclosure had but a single gateway, and not far at all from that great wilderness enclosure there stood a great city — wealthy, prosperous, with good harvests, thoroughly settled by crowds of many people, and delightful — and that great city likewise had but a single gateway, so that all those who entered that great city became filled with joy and met with no destruction. And suppose that in that great city there was a path exceedingly narrow and fearful, just one cubit wide, with vast and terrible chasms on either side plunging a hundred thousand cubits deep. Then, from the midst of that great wilderness enclosure, there arose a single being — wise and calm, of settled mind, wishing to bring benefit to all sentient beings, seeking their happiness, seeking their fulfilment and well-being, wishing to be their physician, endowed with great compassion — and he called out to that great wilderness enclosure, saying: 'O friends! I am here to be your complete protector. Not far from this great wilderness enclosure there is a great city — wealthy, prosperous, happy, blessed with good harvests, and delightful — and all those who enter it will be free from aging and free from death. And I will teach the Dharma so that immeasurable sentient beings may truly cross beyond birth, aging, sickness, and death. Therefore, let all beings of sound intelligence come forward!'"

When that proclamation was made and heard, those sentient beings who were of lesser inclination and possessed the thought of definite renunciation said: "We wish for teachings and guidance right here, without moving from this spot — and may the qualities of that city also arise for us even as we remain here." Those sentient beings of broad aspiration said: "We will go to that city just as you have described it." Those sentient beings of scant merit, however, even upon hearing and listening to that proclamation, did not have faith, and they did not follow the path of that being of wise character.

Then that being of wise character departed from the great wilderness enclosure, and as he left he saw the trail. He saw that the trail was extremely steep and treacherous, descending a great height. He saw that to the right and left of the trail there were great chasms of a hundred thousand cubits in depth. And so he walled off those chasms on the right and left, covered them over with planks, and moved across that trail on all fours — and though those who opposed his return called out with cries of danger and showed signs of fear, he did not look back. Without weariness or discouragement, he continued along that trail. The further along it he went, the more the city came into view, and the more he saw it, the more all its dangers and terrors disappeared entirely. Upon entering the city, there was no aging, no death, and no disease. There was one there who performed the welfare of immeasurable sentient beings and also taught the Dharma so that they might truly be rescued from birth, aging, disease, and death.

Reverend Blessed One, what is called "the great wilderness enclosure" is a metaphorical expression for the wilderness of cyclic existence. What is called "an enclosure equal to the pinnacle of existence" is a metaphorical expression for ignorance and the craving that sustains existence. What is said — "and many hundreds of thousands of living beings entered that great wilderness enclosure" — is a metaphorical expression for all ordinary, childlike beings. What is said — "and that great wilderness enclosure had but a single gate" — is to be understood straightforwardly as referring to the single trail. What is called "a being of wise character" is to be understood as referring to the great bodhisattvas, the great beings. Those who, being of lesser inclination and possessing the thought of definite renunciation, wished neither to stir from that place nor to seek the qualities of the city — they are to be understood as referring to all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Those of broad aspiration who said, "We will go to that city just as you have described it" — they are to be understood as referring to other great bodhisattvas, the great beings. Those sentient beings of scant merit who, even upon hearing that proclamation, did not have faith — they are to be understood as referring to the adherents of non-Buddhist paths (tīrthikas) and wandering mendicants of other schools. What is said — "he departed from the great wilderness enclosure" — is to be understood as referring to one who has set forth with the intention firmly dedicated to omniscience and who has commenced diligent effort.

What is said — "a track the height of a man" — is to be understood as referring to the dharmadhātu, the basic space of phenomena, which one should look

upon in the very manner it is. What is said — "on either side of it, a great abyss some hundred thousand arm-spans wide" — is to be understood as referring to all the grounds of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, which one should look upon in just that way. What is said — "those abysses on either side are hemmed in by walls and flat slabs" — is to be understood as referring to the Perfection of Wisdom and skill in means, which one should look upon in just that way. What is said — "he traverses that track uprightly, crossing it properly with all four limbs" — is to be understood as referring to bodhisattvas, those great beings who, by means of the four means of gathering, gather immeasurable sentient beings and lead them fully across, which one should look upon in just that way. What is said — "though those who oppose from behind keep crying out and showing terrors" — is to be understood as referring to māras and the sons of the gods in māra's host, which one should look upon in just that way; and likewise one should look upon those sentient beings who are deeply attached to evil, who act in all ways under the influence of defiled karma, and who revile and disparage those bodhisattvas. What is said — "he does not look back" — this is the supreme word for the Perfection of patience and for the arousing of mind with elevated aspiration. What is said — "he does not look to either side" — this is the supreme word for having no delight in the grounds of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and for the gnosis of omniscience. What is said — "the great city" — this is the supreme word for the city of omniscience itself. What is said — "the further he advances, the more that city comes into view" — this is the supreme word for the Tathāgata being free from all fear; and likewise it signifies that the bodhisattva comes to see the qualities of the buddhas, gains certain realization of the conduct of the buddhas and of gnosis, and is supremely well trained in the Perfection of Wisdom and in skill in means. What is said — "the more he sees it, the more all terror and all that is terrifying disappears for him" — this is the supreme word signifying that all sentient beings become free from fear and free from doubt. What is said — "upon entering that city, aging and death and illness are no more, and he acts for the benefit of immeasurable sentient beings, and teaches the Dharma for the sake of thoroughly liberating them from birth, aging, illness, and death" — this is the supreme word for the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha.

"Venerable Blessed One, the bodhisattvas, those great beings, are endowed with gnosis. Venerable Blessed One, I pay homage to all bodhisattvas, those great beings."

Then the Blessed One praised the venerable Mahākāśyapa with the words "Excellent!" — "Kāśyapa, excellent, excellent! Kāśyapa, it is indeed excellent that you have aroused such enthusiasm for the bodhisattvas, those great beings. Kāśyapa, through the simile you have recounted, twenty-two thousand living creatures from among gods and humans have aroused the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening. Kāśyapa, the bodhisattvas, those great beings, are ones who are supremely trained in skill in means and are endowed with immeasurable qualities."

"Kāśyapa, a bodhisattva, a great being, does not perform such actions as would cause harm to himself or harm to others, nor does he speak such words as would cause distress to himself or to others."

When the Blessed One had thus declared this, the bodhisattva, the great being Jñānottama (Supreme Wisdom) addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Venerable Blessed One, the Blessed One has declared that a bodhisattva does not speak such words as would cause distress to himself or to others. Blessed One, then why is it that when the bodhisattva who was one birth away from awakening was the brahmin youth named Raśmimālā, the Blessed One — the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha Dīpaṃkara — said to his scriptures: 'What use is a shaven-headed renunciant to me? Since awakening is supremely difficult to attain, what awakening could there be for a shaven-headed renunciant?' What did the Blessed One have in mind when he spoke those words?"

When this was asked, the Blessed One declared the following to the bodhisattva, the great being Jñānottama: "Son of good family, let go of the matter of measuring and distinguishing the conduct of Tathāgatas and of bodhisattvas — what use is that to you? Why so? Son of good family, because the bodhisattvas, those great beings, are endowed with inconceivable skill in means, and those noble beings abide in whatever way will bring about the ripening of sentient beings. Son of good family, that being so, nonetheless listen well and take it properly to heart, for I shall now teach the chapter of Dharma called 'Entry into the Perfection of Skill in Means.' I will teach a portion of that inconceivable skill in means that bodhisattvas have demonstrated, going back as far as the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha Dīpaṃkara.

Son of good family, at the moment when a bodhisattva, immediately upon beholding the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha

Dīpaṃkara, attains forbearance with respect to the non-arising of phenomena — at that very time the bodhisattva is without confusion, without agitation, without forgetfulness, without distraction of mind, and without deterioration of wisdom. Son of good family, a bodhisattva who has attained forbearance with respect to the non-arising of phenomena may, if he wishes, fully and perfectly awaken to buddhahood in seven days; or, if he wishes, in one aeon; or, if he wishes, in one hundred aeons; or, if he wishes, in one thousand aeons; or, if he wishes, in one hundred thousand aeons. And if he so wishes, the bodhisattva may, with full deliberate intention, take rebirth and continue wandering through existence in order to ripen sentient beings. Armed with skill in means and the power of wisdom, whenever he so wishes he fully and perfectly awakens to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening; and if he wishes, he may dwell without weariness of mind for many hundreds of aeons reaching to the uttermost end of the future. That is the bodhisattva's skill in means.

Son of good family, furthermore, while hearers enter into the absorption of peaceful meditative equipoise,"

the bodhisattva also enters into and arises from peaceful meditative absorptions, yet neither his body nor his mind is disturbed in the slightest. A hearer understands only his own individual passage into nirvāṇa; but the bodhisattva, even while entering into peaceful meditative absorptions, never severs his unbroken effort to gather sentient beings through the four means of attraction, ripens sentient beings through the six perfections, and in the very act of ripening sentient beings also gives rise to great compassion. That too is the bodhisattva's skill in means.

Son of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, if he so wishes, could fully and perfectly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and turn the wheel of Dharma while remaining right there in the Tuṣita heaven; yet the bodhisattva thinks to himself: "The human beings of Jambudvīpa cannot ascend to the Tuṣita heaven in order to hear the Dharma, whereas the gods can descend to Jambudvīpa in order to hear the Dharma." For this reason the bodhisattva fully and perfectly awakens to buddhahood right here in Jambudvīpa. That too is the bodhisattva's skill in means.

Son of good family, furthermore, the bodhisattva, if he so wishes, could pass away from the Tuṣita heaven and in that very instant — without entering a mother's womb and without any impurity of the womb, in ignorance alone — fully and perfectly awaken and turn the wheel of Dharma. Yet some sentient

beings would then think to themselves: "Is this a god? A nāga? A yakṣa? A gandharva? An emanation? Where has this one come from?" They would become suspicious, uncertain, and doubtful; and once suspicious, uncertain, and doubtful, they would not listen to the Dharma for the sake of exhausting their afflictions, would not come to know it, would not undertake effort. Therefore the cause, the condition, for the bodhisattva's demonstrating that he dwells in the womb is precisely this. Son of good family, if you were to think that the bodhisattva has actually entered a mother's womb, you should not view it in that way. Why? Because there exists a meditative absorption of the bodhisattva called the Immaculate. While the bodhisattva abides in the Tuṣita heaven, he enters into that absorption, fully relies upon it, and without ever having arisen from that absorption, he sits at the seat of awakening — all while still abiding in the Tuṣita heaven itself. The gods of Tuṣita, for their part, simply do not see him there and thus know only that the bodhisattva has arisen from his absorption. The bodhisattva, without stirring from the Tuṣita heaven, displays through emanations the departure, the birth, the going forth, and all the deeds of ascetic practice. All of these are displayed everywhere by the bodhisattva through emanations. Why? Because, son of good family, the bodhisattva's conduct is utterly pure, and therefore he does not return to a mother's womb. That too is the bodhisattva's skill in means.

As to why the bodhisattva displays himself transforming into a great white elephant and entering the mother's womb — that is an expression belonging to the side of virtue. Why?

Because the bodhisattva is supremely distinguished above all sentient beings, it is necessary to show that he enters the womb in a manner unlike anything possessed by any god or any other human being — and that too is the bodhisattva's skill in means.

As to why the bodhisattva dwells in the womb for ten months and not nine: there are sentient beings who might think, "Alas, this youth did not complete the full term of dwelling in the womb, and so his faculties have come to be incomplete." In order to cut through the doubt of such sentient beings, and to display fully both the proper term of the womb and the complete perfection of his faculties, the bodhisattva dwells in the womb for ten months and not nine. And while the bodhisattva is dwelling in the womb for those ten months, the gods come to behold the bodhisattva, to pay homage, and to render him veneration. They behold the bodhisattva's palace of precious adornments, arrayed with magnificent furnishings, utterly surpassing all the enjoyments of

the gods, while he resides in the womb of his mother the goddess. Seeing this, two hundred million sons of the gods and four hundred thousand of them generate the awakening mind aimed at unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. That too is the bodhisattva's skill in means.

As to why the bodhisattva is displayed emerging from the right side of his mother's body and issuing forth from the womb: there are sentient beings who might think, "The bodhisattva was not born from the womb of a father and mother but was instead born by miraculous transformation." In order to cut through the doubt of such sentient beings, the bodhisattva is displayed emerging from the right side of his mother's body and issuing forth from the womb. And the moment he emerges, the body of the mother goddess — a magical emanation body — bears no wound and no blemish; and the bliss that the mother goddess experienced through the magical emanation while the bodhisattva resided in the womb is the kind of bliss that had never before been touched or experienced at any prior time. That too is the bodhisattva's skill in means.

As to why the bodhisattva was born in a forest grove and not in a town: the bodhisattva has long been one who sings the praises of solitude, who delights in seclusion, and whose conduct is utterly pure; and if he were born in a town, the gods, nāgas, and yakṣas would not perform the magnificent worship with divine powders, incense, garlands, unguents, and flowers; and moreover, the people dwelling in the city of the Śākyas' seat would give rise to pride and heedlessness. That is the cause, and that is the condition, for which the bodhisattva was born in a forest grove and not in a town.

As to why the mother goddess, grasping the branch of a plakṣa tree, gave birth to the bodhisattva without making use of a bed: there are sentient beings who might think, "Did the mother goddess, like other women, bring forth the bodhisattva while being touched by a feeling of pain?" In order to cut through the doubt of such sentient beings, and to display fully that the birth was comfortable and at ease, the mother goddess, grasping the branch of a plakṣa tree in the form of a magical emanation, gave birth to the bodhisattva without making use of a bed.

As to why the bodhisattva, with mindfulness and introspective awareness, emerged from the womb through the right side of his mother's body — and not from the birth passage, nor from any other part of the body: the bodhisattva's conduct is utterly pure, he is supremely distinguished above all three worlds,

In order to tame the sentient beings who are to be tamed, he needed to demonstrate a birth that was not like that of other, inferior sentient beings — one in which he had not depended upon and dwelt inside a mother's womb, and was not born through an impure passage. Therefore the bodhisattva pierced open his mother's right side, and with mindfulness and introspective awareness emerged from the womb. The moment the bodhisattva was born, the mother goddess's magically emanated side was restored: without wound and without scar. This too is the bodhisattva's mastery in skillful means.

Why was it that the moment the bodhisattva was born, it was Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, who received him, and not some other person? It is because the bodhisattva's roots of virtue blazed forth, inspiring the gods with eager devotion, and Śakra had previously made this aspiration: "The moment the bodhisattva is born, I myself shall receive him, wrapped in a precious cloth." It is on account of that earlier aspiration that he now applies himself with great effort to the vast act of making offering to the bodhisattva. This too is the bodhisattva's mastery in skillful means.

Why is it that the moment the bodhisattva was born, without anyone supporting him, he took exactly seven steps — and not six, and not eight? It is because the bodhisattva needed to demonstrate without fail, as no one else ever had before, his great and wondrous power wrought through miraculous strength, and the unfailing excellence of a supreme being. As for the purpose served by the seven steps — the benefit intended for those sentient beings — six steps would have been insufficient, while eight would have been excessive. Therefore the moment the bodhisattva was born, without anyone supporting him, he took seven steps and not six and not eight. This too is the bodhisattva's mastery in skillful means.

Why is it that when the bodhisattva took those seven steps, he uttered these words: "I am the foremost in the world; I am the chief in the world; I shall bring birth, aging, sickness, and death to their final end"?

Sons of good family, gathered there at that time were Śakra, Brahmā, and sons of the gods of great renown — and those assembled ones, filled with pride, were thinking to themselves: "We are the most exalted. This bodhisattva is not so." With such thoughts they did not bow, did not bow deeply, did not pay homage, did not pay deep homage. Therefore the bodhisattva thought: "These sons of the gods — Śakra, Brahmā, and the others — will for a long time come to experience what is without purpose, what

is harmful, what is suffering, and what leads them astray."

And so it was for this reason that the bodhisattva spoke these words: "I am the foremost in the world; I am the chief in the world; I shall bring birth, aging, sickness, and death to their final end." The sound of those words was heard throughout this entire world-system of a great trichiliocosm, and those sons of the gods who had not yet arrived, upon hearing that sound, now came. Then those sons of the gods, together with Śakra and Brahmā, were filled with wonder and astonishment, and with reverence they pressed their palms together and bowed down fully before the bodhisattva, paying him homage. The cause and the condition for which the bodhisattva spoke those words — "I am the chief in the world; I shall bring birth, aging, sickness, and death to their final end" — was just this. The words of the bodhisattva were true. This too is the bodhisattva's mastery in skillful means.

Why does the bodhisattva laugh loudly immediately upon being born? Noble son, in the bodhisattva there is no wild, unrestrained laughter born together with attachment, born together with aversion, or born together with delusion — nor does he laugh in the manner of a horse's whinny. Rather, the bodhisattva thinks to himself: "These other bodhisattvas who once aroused the mind of awakening together with me have now fallen under the power of laziness and remain sunk deep in cyclic existence, while I have attained awakening. Alas, these sentient beings do not apply diligent effort to all the qualities by which one must traverse the path with compassion in order to attain omniscience." Thinking in this way and arousing great compassion, he recognizes that when those sentient beings see him, they will understand that the bodhisattva has fully perfected his aspiration and that they themselves are inferior and heedless, and so they will now bow down before him. It is for this reason that the bodhisattva laughs loudly. This too is the bodhisattva's mastery in skillful means.

Why, immediately upon the bodhisattva's pure and stainless birth, do Śakra (Indra, king of the gods) and Brahmā bathe him? Noble son, on the one hand, Śakra and Brahmā are performing an act of veneration. On the other hand, in the world it is the unfailing custom that newborn children are bathed immediately, and so the bodhisattva too must unfailingly enter into the ways that the world knows and follows. Seeing the purpose of this, the bodhisattva arranges that immediately upon his birth Śakra and Brahmā bathe him. This too is the bodhisattva's mastery in skillful means.

Why, immediately upon being born in the wilderness, does the bodhisattva not go directly to the seat of awakening but instead enter a city? It is in order to demonstrate fully the ripening of the sense faculties, to demonstrate fully the activities of a queen's retinue, to demonstrate fully pleasures and sports, and then — having thus shown all of this and having turned away from the four great continents without a glance — to demonstrate the full going forth into renunciation. In this way, other sentient beings who follow his example, likewise abandoning the pleasures, sports, enjoyments, and vast retinues of desire, will be moved to go forth into renunciation. This is the cause and this is the condition for which the bodhisattva, immediately upon being born in the wilderness, does not go directly to the seat of awakening but enters a city and then accomplishes the full going forth. This too is the bodhisattva's mastery in skillful means.

Why, when seven days have passed since the bodhisattva's birth, does his divine mother Māyādevī pass away? In this there is no fault on the part of the bodhisattva. Māyādevī herself had exhausted her lifespan and passed away at her appointed time — it is not the bodhisattva's fault. For when the bodhisattva was still dwelling in the supreme divine realm of Tuṣita, he examined with his pure divine eye the remaining lifespan of Māyādevī, and he knew that she had no more than ten months and seven days left to live. It was only after this examination that the bodhisattva passed away from the supreme realm of Tuṣita and entered his mother's womb. Therefore, noble son, by this very enumeration of reasons you should understand that it was simply Māyādevī herself who, having exhausted her lifespan, passed away at her time — it is not the fault of the bodhisattva's birth. This too is the bodhisattva's mastery in skillful means.

Why did the bodhisattva train so thoroughly in writing, arithmetic, treatises, numbers and calculation, the art of the sword, the art of the bow, feats of strength, the wrestler's grip, the reading of stars, sport, and games? It was in order to accord with the world. For there is no craft, no secret mantra, no knowledge mantra, no treatise, no dance, no song, no musical sound, no comedy, no charm, no sport, no game that the bodhisattva did not train in perfectly from the very beginning — and yet there is nothing of this kind to be demonstrated anywhere throughout the great trichiliocosm. Nevertheless, for the bodhisattva, at the very moment of his birth, all worldly and transcendent crafts and domains of activity became fully manifest. Why is this? Because of the power of mastery produced by his having trained excellently in former

times and by the full ripening of his roots of virtue. This too is the bodhisattva's mastery in skillful means.

Why does the bodhisattva in his final existence take queens, consorts, and retinues of attendants? Noble son, the bodhisattva does not pursue sensual pleasures for their own sake. Why? Because at that stage the holy man is free from attachment. And yet it is absolutely necessary that the bodhisattva in his final existence be seen with a retinue of queens, consorts, and children — for if sentient beings were to think, "This bodhisattva is no holy man; he must be of a degenerate lineage," such beings would fall, for a very long time, into futility, harm, suffering, and wrong courses. Therefore, to cut through the doubts of those sentient beings and to demonstrate the scene of the son Rāhula openly for all to see, the bodhisattva took the Śākya princess Yaśodharā as his wife. As for those who think that Rāhula was born from the union of father and mother — let them not hold that view. Why? Because Rāhula had previously made this aspiration: "May I be born as the son of the one in his final existence." And so Rāhula passed away from the divine realm and was born here by miraculous apparitional birth — he was not born from the physical union of father and mother. As for the Śākya princess Yaśodharā, she too was taken by the power of a former aspiration. In the presence of the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara she had prayed, "O brahmin youth, when you arrive at your final existence, may you become my husband, and may I become your queen." And at that time the bodhisattva also said, "Good woman, I do not pursue sensual pleasures for their own sake, and yet may it be as you wish" — and for the sake of the lotus flower, he accepted. Since the roots of virtue established in the presence of a buddha are unfailing, the bodhisattva took the Śākya princess Yaśodharā as his wife.

Furthermore, it is absolutely necessary that the bodhisattva in his final existence be seen with a retinue of queens and attendants. For it was precisely by seeing the bodhisattva's perfect form, his perfect divine honors, and his perfect manner of going forth that the Śākya princess Yaśodharā thought, "Alas, may I too come to possess such qualities as these!" — and with this elevated aspiration she aroused the awakening mind directed toward unsurpassed, perfect, complete enlightenment. And so, in order to firmly establish the Śākya princess Yaśodharā in the awakening mind, the bodhisattva took the Śākya princess Yaśodharā as his wife.

Furthermore, in order to demonstrate to those sentient beings who, entangled in the net of desires, servants, wives, the limits of their work, their households,

and their wealth and possessions, are unable to renounce and go forth — in order to show such beings the way to look without attachment on craving for sense pleasures, on enjoyments, wealth, possessions, and wives — the bodhisattva took the Śākya princess Yaśodharā as his wife and then, without so much as a glance at his home, his wealth, his wife, or his retinue, abandoned them and went forth. If he had done so, those very beings would think to themselves: "This young man, in whom every aim is fulfilled, likewise cast aside his queen, his wealth, his retinue, and his vast enjoyments without a backward glance and went forth — why then should we not go forth as well?" It was in order to arouse just such a thought in them that he acted as he did.

The third section.

Furthermore, when the bodhisattva in former times was practicing the conduct of a bodhisattva, there were young women attendants whom he had thoroughly ripened in wholesome qualities and in whom he had inspired devotion. These women had made the aspiration: "May we be your queen throughout all our existences until saṃsāra is exhausted." In order to bring the white, virtuous qualities of such women to full maturation, the bodhisattva took them as his retinue. Among the women dwelling within the bodhisattva's circle of queens at that time, forty-two thousand were thoroughly ripened toward unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. The remainder were established in the quality of non-regression. In this way too the bodhisattva took those women as his retinue.

Furthermore, there were women who were tormented by a great and burning affliction of attachment. The moment such a woman saw the bodhisattva, she would come to know that her own self was free from attachment — and it was for this purpose that he was as he was. Moreover, the bodhisattva manifested an emanation bearing his own proportions, color, and form in every detail, and that emanation would sport, play, and take delight together with those women. Each of them would think to herself, "I am sporting, playing, and taking delight together with the bodhisattva" — yet the bodhisattva himself remained dwelling in the bliss of meditative concentration. The sensory enjoyments of the emanation should be understood as being of just that nature, and the sensory enjoyments of the bodhisattva himself should be understood as similar in that way, extending back all the way from the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly complete buddha Dīpaṃkara. The two companions of the Śākya clan, Sundarananda and Aśvajit, should be understood as having been connected to the bodhisattva through their own former aspirations. This

too should be understood as the bodhisattva's skillful means.

Why did the bodhisattva meditate in the shade of the rose-apple tree? It was because, dwelling there, he was to tame seventy million gods and to properly teach both his father and his mother; because he was to demonstrate, unmistakably and fully, his own going forth as a renunciant, and his great wisdom; and because he was to demonstrate fully the very fact that the shade of the rose-apple tree had not shifted. These are the causes and conditions for the bodhisattva's meditating in the shade of the rose-apple tree. This too should be understood as the bodhisattva's skillful means.

Why did the bodhisattva, who did not seek after delight and amusement of any kind, go to the pleasure grove? It was in order to reveal fully the sight of an old person, a sick person, and a dead person,

so that the relatives would come to understand in this way: that the bodhisattva was not averse to his relatives, but rather, having recognized that old age, sickness, and death are terrifying and frightening, and that living in a household is a place marred by many faults and is not a fit abode, he went forth — this was to be demonstrated fully to them all. And it was also to demonstrate fully to all sentient beings the terror of old age, sickness, and death. For these reasons, even though the bodhisattva did not seek after delight and amusement of any kind, he came to the pleasure grove. This too should be understood as the bodhisattva's skillful means.

Why did the bodhisattva go forth in the middle of the night and not by day? It was in order to demonstrate fully the root of virtue by which, when sentient beings abide in it, their roots of virtue would increase. A son of good family who seeks the white teachings (virtuous dharmas) must utterly renounce whatever great pleasures there are, and at the hour of midnight, without asking or looking to anyone else, he must go forth; and he must utterly relinquish all the requisites of comfort — this was to be demonstrated. And it was so that the side of virtue would not be caused to degenerate. This too should be understood as the bodhisattva's skillful means.

Why did the bodhisattva cause the people to fall asleep and then depart? It was so that the gods would cause the people to fall asleep and thereby demonstrate the fault committed by the gods. For if the relatives and the people had aroused contempt and aversion toward the bodhisattva, that would have resulted, for a very long time, in their being without purpose, in harm, in suffering, and in their falling into wrong. But if the gods were to cause

those very people to fall asleep and open the gates and carry them up into the air, and those people were then to understand that this had pleased the bodhisattva, they would come to have great faith in the bodhisattva. It was because he saw this beneficial purpose that he caused the people to fall asleep and departed. This too should be understood as the bodhisattva's skillful means.

Why did the bodhisattva send back the horse and the ornaments to the Śākya attendant? It was in order to demonstrate fully the quality of knowing contentment, so that others could say: "The bodhisattva, having gone forth without looking upon any possessions whatsoever, is therefore not one who seeks gold and silver." And furthermore, it was in order to guide the people of future generations to train themselves accordingly. He intended to demonstrate: "Those who would go forth in this teaching of mine should train after me, and should go forth without looking upon any possessions whatsoever, depending upon the four noble standards. And one who has gone forth must not, from the very beginning, go forth while looking to livelihood." This too should be understood as the bodhisattva's skillful means.

Why did the bodhisattva cut his own hair with a sword and go forth himself? It was to demonstrate fully to this son of good family that there is no god, nāga, yakṣa, gandharva (fragrance-eater), human being, or non-human being anywhere within the great trichiliocosm — the system of three thousand great thousand worlds — who could bear the weight of the bodhisattva's splendor and majesty and thereby consent to cut his hair; and it was to demonstrate that the bodhisattva himself, in seeking to go forth, was one endowed with faith.

And if, when the bodhisattva had cut his own hair and gone forth himself, King Śuddhodana had become displeased and cried, "Who has cut my son's hair — who has severed it by cutting?" — then, so that upon hearing that the bodhisattva had cut his own hair with his own sword King Śuddhodana would have nothing to say, this too should be understood as the bodhisattva's skillful means.

Then the Blessed One again addressed the bodhisattva Jñānottama: Son of good family, hear now also why it was that the bodhisattva practiced austerities for six years. It was because the bodhisattva, through his skillful means, sought to inspire in sentient beings a definite weariness with their non-virtuous actions and a firm aspiration to turn away from them. Son of

good family, thus it was that the bodhisattva, in the scriptural collection of the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa, said these words: "What use is a shaven-headed ascetic to me? Since awakening is supremely difficult to obtain, how could awakening possibly belong to a shaven-headed ascetic?" That too should be seen as the bodhisattva's skillful means and as indirect speech. It was on account of the karmic obscuration of that karma that the bodhisattva practiced austerities for six years.

Why did the bodhisattva think to say those words? Son of good family, at that time, in the scriptural collection of the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa, there was a brahmin youth named Raśmijāla, and there were five sons of good family — youths like great śāla trees of brahmin stock — who had genuinely entered the bodhisattva's vehicle. These five fell under the power of evil companions and, upon meeting evil companions, forgot their awakening mind. At that time those five sons of good family took up the ascetic practice of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) and abandoned the ascetic practice of the buddhas; they applied themselves to the secret mantras of non-Buddhists and not to the secret mantras of the buddhas; they were devoted to non-Buddhists, and under the influence of non-Buddhists they boasted, claiming: "Awakening belongs to us — we too are buddhas."

The brahmin youth Raśmijāla recognized that those five sons of good family were receptive vessels, and through his skillful means he wished to draw them gradually away from those non-Buddhists. Therefore, through his skillful means, he said to the potter Kumbhakāra these very words: "What use is a shaven-headed ascetic to me? Since awakening is supremely difficult to obtain, how could awakening possibly belong to a shaven-headed ascetic?" Then, son of good family, the brahmin youth Raśmijāla went to another place and remained there together with those five youths like great śāla trees of brahmin stock.

Thereupon the potter Kumbhakāra went to that very place, and while extolling and praising the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa, he spoke these words to the brahmin youth Raśmijāla: "Ho, Raśmijāla, come here — come into the presence of the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa!"

Son of good family, at that point the brahmin youth Raśmijāla thought to himself: "Alas, these brahmin youths have not yet brought their roots of virtue to full ripening. If I were to go into the presence of the Tathāgata, arhat, fully

and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa together with these five —"

"— then these sons of good family would become altogether suspicious, and there would be a very real possibility that they would not come into the presence of the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa." And so, keeping firm to that very vow he had already taken, and being skilled in the means concordant with the Perfection of Wisdom, the brahmin youth Raśmijāla spoke these words: "What use is it to me to see a shaven-headed ascetic touch my head? Awakening is supremely difficult to find — how could awakening be found in a shaven-headed ascetic?" And how, one may ask, was he skilled in the means concordant with the Perfection of Wisdom? Because a bodhisattva who practices the Perfection of Wisdom has no perception of awakening and no perception of a buddha; he does not truly see any buddha that could be called "a buddha," nor does he truly see any awakening. Awakening is not truly seen within; awakening is not truly seen without; awakening is not truly seen within and without together. This is because all phenomena are unborn and beyond apprehension, and awakening therefore is utterly empty. For this reason, being skilled in the means concordant with the Perfection of Wisdom, the brahmin youth Raśmijāla spoke these words: "What use is it to me to see a shaven-headed ascetic touch my head? Awakening is supremely difficult to find — how could awakening be found in a shaven-headed ascetic?"

Then, at another time, the brahmin youth Raśmijāla was at a riverbank together with those five youths. By the power of the Buddha, and in order to tame those five sons of good family, the potter Kumbhakāra went to that very riverbank and addressed the brahmin youth Raśmijāla as follows: "Ho, Raśmijāla, come here! The appearance of buddhas, blessed ones, in the world is extremely rare. Let us go to see the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa, to pay homage, and to render him service."

The brahmin youth Raśmijāla replied: "What use is it to me to see a shaven-headed ascetic touch my head? Awakening is supremely difficult to find — how could awakening be found in a shaven-headed ascetic?"

And since the brahmin youth Raśmijāla would not go to see the Tathāgata, to pay homage, and to render him service, the potter Kumbhakāra then took hold of the brahmin youth Raśmijāla by his topknot and led him to where the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa was.

The five brahmin youths surrounded the brahmin youth Raśmijāla and, with minds full of eager devotion, went to where the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa was.

Then those five who had been born into the household of the brahmin youth whose view was distorted — great as the sal tree, scion of brahmin lineage — were greatly inspired. They thought to themselves: "In this way, while the potter Kumbhakāra holds him by his very topknot, this brahmin youth Raśmijāla is being brought to see the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa, to pay homage, to render him service, to approach him, and to perfect wholesome Dharma — and he goes even at the cost of his own life being entirely surrendered.

"What manner of buddha is this buddha in whose presence one will come before the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa? What manner of thing is the Dharma of a buddha?" And so those five, great as the sal tree, scions of brahmin lineage, formed their resolve and went straight toward the Tathāgata Kāśyapa in order to behold the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa. The very moment they saw the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa, stirred by their previously accumulated roots of virtue, they attained faith. Having attained faith, they rebuked the brahmin youth Raśmijāla, saying: "Qualities of the Teacher such as these — why did you never speak of them to us before?"

Noble son, thereupon those five, great as the sal tree, scions of brahmin lineage, also beheld the splendor and majesty of the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa; they also heard his fearlessness, and heard the proclamation of his Brahmā-like voice. With heightened intention they gave rise to the mind directed toward unsurpassable, fully and perfectly awakened enlightenment.

Noble son, the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa, having understood with complete comprehension the heightened intention of those noble sons, then and there taught — fully and accurately — a Dharma exposition belonging to the collection of the bodhisattva scriptural basket, namely the dhāraṇī of the irreversible wheel, with its vajra-like phrasing: "All phenomena are unborn." Through this, those five noble sons attained the patient acceptance of the arising of no phenomena.

Noble son, it is thus: because I, possessing the unobstructed wisdom of a buddha, prophesy to you — if the brahmin youth Raśmijāla, in the presence of

those noble sons, were to sing the praises of the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa while speaking disparagingly of the non-Buddhists, then, even without there being the opportunity or occasion for those noble sons to go before the Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha Kāśyapa, they would still attain faith — to say nothing of when such an opportunity does exist. That is an impossibility.

Noble son, it is thus: in order to bring to full maturation those five noble sons who had genuinely entered the vehicle of the bodhisattva, the brahmin youth Raśmijāla, being skilled in the means concordant with the Perfection of Wisdom, spoke these words: "What use to me is a śramaṇa who merely pats my head? Enlightenment is supremely difficult to find — how could there be enlightenment from a head-patting śramaṇa?" — and said no more than that. Noble son, an irreversible bodhisattva harbors no resentment toward a buddha, no doubt about enlightenment, and no doubt about the qualities of a buddha; and this too is the skillful means of a bodhisattva.

Noble son, as for what deed it was by which he fully matured those bodhisattvas and revealed the karmic maturation of action — through the karmic maturation of that deed, it fell to me to practice austerities for six years. Others, who acted unknowingly like sentient beings, spoke harsh words in secret against virtuous śramaṇas and brahmins of good moral discipline; and whether those others knew or did not know, whether they possessed understanding or did not possess understanding, if such words were uttered, those beings would, for a long time, experience what is without benefit, what is harmful, and what is suffering —

they would fall into wrong ways. Therefore, in order to show sentient beings the workings of karma, the Tathāgata revealed that karma fully and completely to them — but as for the bodhisattva himself, there was not even the slightest karmic obscuration.

Furthermore, there are sentient beings who, having spoken harsh words against virtuous śramaṇas and brahmins possessed of moral discipline, think, "There is no possibility of liberation for me," and remain in remorse without making further effort. In order to dispel that remorse in such sentient beings, that karma was also fully revealed — so that they might think: "Even though the bodhisattva, who is only one birth away from buddhahood, uttered these very words in the scriptures of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened one Kāśyapa — saying, 'Awakening is supremely difficult to attain;

how could a wandering monk (śramaṇa) who merely touches someone's head attain awakening?' — and yet he too had the possibility of complete liberation, what need is there to speak of us who acted unknowingly?" And so, thinking thus, those beings would come to recognize the fault of that sinful action, and others too would refrain from accumulating it.

Noble child, for yet another reason — in order to tame tīrthikas — the bodhisattva fully displayed the practice of austerities for six years; it was not due to karmic obscuration. Why is that? Because there are śramaṇas and brahmins who believe that purity is achieved by eating only a single grain of pine needle, sesame, or rice, and nothing else, in order to refute them the bodhisattva demonstrated that purity cannot be achieved by eating such poor food — a single grain of pine needle, sesame, or rice — without relying on the noble path. Thus the bodhisattva spoke these very words: "Awakening is supremely difficult to attain; how could a wandering monk who merely touches someone's head attain awakening?" That was the cause, and that was the condition — and, directing attention toward that karmic deed, the practice of austerities for six years was displayed.

By the bodhisattva's display of practicing austerities for six years, four million two hundred thousand beings who were devoted to the wicked ascetics of gods and non-Buddhists were tamed through that poor food, and they came to realize and actualize gnosis. That too was the bodhisattva's skillful means.

As to why the bodhisattva then fully partook of food and properly nourished the strength, force, and power of his body before going to the foot of the tree of awakening — why did he not go with a weakened and emaciated body? If the bodhisattva, even with a body weakened and emaciated from not eating, was capable of manifestly and perfectly attaining full awakening, then how much more so after eating even poor food! However, out of compassion for those later beings whose roots of virtue had not yet fully ripened — those who, thinking that they would fully seek awakening by refraining from eating, were so utterly tormented by hunger that they would be unable to accomplish gnosis — out of compassion for them, the bodhisattva fully partook of food.

And why? Because those who are at ease are able to teach and proclaim the Dharma, while those who are in suffering cannot. Therefore, wishing to reveal to those sentient beings that gnosis is realized in a state of ease, he acted accordingly. How so? The bodhisattva himself fully partook of the food of the village girl, and so that sentient beings would learn from his example —

thinking, "It was through the very ease of food that the bodhisattva attained awakening" — he did so for their sake. And so it was simply in order to perfect the dharmas conducive to awakening for the village girl Sujātā, and out of compassion for later beings, that the bodhisattva fully partook of her food and it was fully displayed as attaining awakening thereby.

Noble child, the bodhisattva, through the joy of meditative concentration and meditative absorption,

supreme joy alone is sufficient to sustain one for many hundreds of thousands of aeons without food. This too is the bodhisattva's mastery of skillful means.

Why does the bodhisattva request grass? Because those Tathāgatas of the past as well likewise held grass-seats in high regard, and a grass mat sufficed as a cushion — out of contentment with that, and in order to perfect the dharmas conducive to awakening for Svāstika, the auspicious grass-seller.

And because he offered grass to the bodhisattva, he then aroused the awakening mind aspiring to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — and so I prophesied that in a future time he shall become a Tathāgata, arhat, fully and perfectly awakened buddha by the name "Free from Dust." This too is the bodhisattva's mastery of skillful means.

Why does the bodhisattva, while sitting at the foot of the awakening tree, not swiftly proceed to the manifest, perfect, complete awakening before Māra the Evil One can arrive? Noble child, it is utterly without basis and without occasion for Māra the Evil One to come to the foot of the awakening tree when the bodhisattva has not yet opened the way for him. There is no place for it. And yet, noble child, even so, when the bodhisattva is seated at the foot of the awakening tree he thinks to himself: "In this desire realm of the great fourfold continent, who is the lord? Under whose power do these sentient beings fall?" And then he thinks: "It is Māra the Evil One — they have fallen under his power." Thereupon the bodhisattva thinks: "If I engage Māra the Evil One in battle and vanquish him, I shall have conquered the whole of the desire realm, and vast hosts of Māra's retinue will assemble — retinues of yakṣas, retinues of rākṣasas (Skt. rākṣasa), retinues of gandharvas (Skt. gandharva), and retinues of asuras. And when those many assembled retinues behold the bodhisattva's lion-like play, they will arouse the awakening mind aspiring to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening and make aspirational prayers. Moreover, all others who see this will thereby be given a cause that shall serve them until they pass completely beyond sorrow."

Noble child, thereupon, while seated at the foot of the awakening tree, the bodhisattva emitted from his ūṛṇā hair a blazing radiance. This light illuminated the great trichiliocosm, overwhelming even the light of the sun and the moon, and caused all the abodes of Māra to fall dark. And from within that light there arose a sound of this kind: "The son of the Śākya has gone forth from the Śākya capital, and he is going to fully and perfectly awaken to awakening. He will thus pass beyond Māra's domain, and countless hundreds of thousands of sentient beings will also be led to pass beyond Māra's domain. The side of Māra will be diminished; the hosts of Māra will be reduced. Go, therefore, and do battle with him!"

Noble child, when that light thereby stirred Māra the Evil One to action, Māra was pierced by a great anguish of grief, and in fury and ferocity he immediately marshaled and assembled a fourfold army, and went toward the foot of the awakening tree. In order to obstruct the bodhisattva, he filled a surrounding area of thirty-two leagues in every direction with the armies of Māra.

Then the bodhisattva, abiding in great wisdom, great loving-kindness, and great compassion, struck the great earth with his right hand — golden in color, born of precious wisdom — and through the power of loving-kindness he defeated the entire host of Māra.

The moment the host of Māra was defeated, gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, kinnaras (Skt. kinnara), and

mahorāgas and eighty-four million water-pots worth of beings beheld the bodhisattva's splendor, majesty, complexion, form, and bearing, and beheld his power, force, might, and lion-like sport — and thereupon generated the awakening mind aimed at unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening. This too is the Tathāgata's skill in skillful means.

Why did the Tathāgata, after attaining awakening, remain for seven days seated in cross-legged posture without stirring, gazing unwaveringly at the king of trees? At that time, certain deity-sons who dwelt in the form realm and who practiced utterly peaceful conduct were also present there. When they saw the Tathāgata seated in cross-legged posture, a vast joy, serenity, and supreme delight arose in them. And having thus been filled with joy, serenity, and supreme delight, they thought to themselves: "We must carefully examine what it is that the mind of the ascetic Gautama rests upon." For seven days they concentrated their minds and investigated — yet they could not fathom

what the mind of the Tathāgata rested upon. Then, with vast joy, serenity, and supreme delight having arisen, thirty-two thousand deity-sons generated the awakening mind aimed at unsurpassable, perfect, complete awakening, aspiring thus: "May we too, in a future time, meditate upon the awakening tree with such utterly peaceful conduct."

That, then, is the cause and condition why the Tathāgata, after attaining awakening, remained for seven days seated in cross-legged posture without stirring, gazing unwaveringly at the king of trees. This is the Tathāgata's skill in skillful means.

Now, why is it that, having for countless aeons opened the gates of liberation and breathed life into all sentient beings as his guests, the Tathāgata did not teach the Dharma without first being requested by Brahmā? In this regard, noble son, the Tathāgata reflected thus: "The world, together with its gods and humans, largely relies upon Brahmā and regards Brahmā as supreme. They think: 'We are Brahmā's emanations; we were born from Brahmā. Apart from Brahmā there is no other maker of the world and no other teacher.' Therefore the Tathāgata reflected: 'I shall have Brahmā come to me, and I shall remain in Brahmā's presence; when Brahmā has paid homage, the world together with its gods — which relies upon Brahmā — will also pay homage to the Tathāgata. And when Brahmā makes a request, the Tathāgata will teach the Dharma; but if I were to teach without being asked, they might not be certain to receive my Dharma.'"

And as for Brahmā himself — he came solely through the power of the Tathāgata himself, in order to make the request that the wheel of Dharma be turned; there was not even the slightest thought in Brahmā's own mind of "I shall make a request of the Tathāgata."

Thus, in order to remove from those sentient beings who rely upon Brahmā their fixed attachment to Brahmā, the Tathāgata caused Brahmā to come and abided in Brahmā's presence. And when Brahmā made the request that the wheel of Dharma be turned — that is, when Brahmā supplicated the Tathāgata — at that very moment sixty-eight thousand Brahmās thought: "This blessed Buddha, this Blessed One, is the highest of all sentient beings. He is the chief. He is the supremely excellent one. May we too attain a wisdom such as this, and

be endowed with such qualities." And so they aroused the awakening mind aimed at unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. This too is the

Tathāgata's skill in means.

Then the Blessed One spoke again to the bodhisattva Jñānottama: "Noble son, that the Tathāgata has taught these ten threads of karma to sentient beings is also to be understood as the skill in means of a bodhisattva and a Tathāgata, and is also to be understood as skillful speech. For, noble son, if a bodhisattva possesses even so much as a fraction of non-virtue as fine as the tip of a hair, there is no ground, no occasion, for sitting at the seat of awakening beneath the tree of awakening and fully realizing unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening. That is an impossibility. Why is this so? Noble son, a Tathāgata is endowed with all virtuous qualities and has abandoned all abandonment of unwholesome qualities. As for the Tathāgata, there is not even a trace of the residual habitual tendency of intimacy with the accumulation of sinful action yet to be abandoned — to say nothing, then, of karmic obscuration. That, therefore, is an impossibility.

Yet in order to demonstrate karmic maturation fully to those sentient beings who squander their karmic maturation and who have no faith in karmic maturation, the Tathāgata also teaches the threads of karma comprehensively, thinking: 'If even for me, the lord of Dharma, karmic maturation arises, why should it not arise for you?' — teaching karmic maturation comprehensively to those beings. It is for this purpose that the Tathāgata teaches the threads of karma; but the Tathāgata himself has not even the slightest karmic obscuration.

Noble son, consider this analogy: a teacher who is fully trained in letters, arithmetic, and computation — wishing to teach children — has the children read out the model letters merely as a way of calling them forth, though the teacher himself has no ignorance or obscuration with respect to those subjects. Yet he has the children read the models so that they, having heard it from him, will in every way learn and become proficient in letters, arithmetic, computation, and enumeration. In just the same way, noble son, the Tathāgata, who is fully trained in all Dharmas, teaches and demonstrates karma however is needed, in whatever way will best purify the karma of other sentient beings.

Noble son, consider further this analogy: a physician fully trained in curing all illness, though himself free from disease, tastes bitter medicines before sick sentient beings, praises them, and speaks their praises again and again. The patients, seeing this, then drink those bitter medicines, make full use of them,

and thereby become completely liberated from those illnesses. In the same way, noble son, the Tathāgata — the great king of physicians, fully liberated from all the illnesses of mental affliction, having attained freedom from all obscurations with respect to all Dharmas — comprehensively teaches karma, saying: 'The ripened fruit of this virtuous and non-virtuous karma is such and such.' He teaches karma comprehensively, reflecting on how sentient beings, who are frightened and terrified by karmic obscuration, may have their bodily karma, their verbal karma, and their mental karma completely purified. Noble son, consider again this analogy:

Just as when a merchant's son or a householder's son has been born and, before long, his parents provide a wet-nurse for him — and that wet-nurse, though herself free from illness, thinks: "I must thoroughly purify this child's milk," and so takes medicines, both cold and hot, and examines each one and drinks them — in precisely the same way, noble son, the Tathāgata, who is also the father of all the world, and who has himself attained freedom from illness, teaches karma comprehensively for the sake of bringing to full maturation those sentient beings who are still caught up in the workings of karma. When those sentient beings hear that "such and such is the karmic maturation of a particular karma," they come to feel disenchantment, and being disenchanted they no longer actively engage in sinful deeds. This too is the Tathāgata's skill in skillful means.

Then the Blessed One once again spoke to the bodhisattva Jñānottama, saying: Noble son, in the past, in a time long gone by, there was a Tathāgata, an arhat, a fully and perfectly awakened buddha called Dīpaṃkara. Far beyond, on the further shore from that buddha's realm, there was a great ocean, and into that great ocean had entered a company of about five hundred merchants eager for wealth. Now among that very company there was a man of dark deeds, a man who performed sinful actions, well trained in the skills of deception, a thief, one who, under the guise of a merchant's way of life, robbed others of their wealth — and he too had boarded that very great ship.

Then that man thought to himself: "At the moment when these merchants have accomplished their purpose and completed their business, I will kill all these merchants, take every kind of their valuables and wealth, and go to Jambudvīpa." Noble son, then those merchants accomplished their purpose and were eager to return to the other shore. At that point the man of treacherous nature thought: "Now the time has come for me to kill all these

merchants, take all their valuables and wealth, and go to Jambudvīpa."

Now at that very time there was also on board that same great ship a ship's captain by the name of Mahākaruṇika, "the One Possessed of Great Compassion." The captain Mahākaruṇika fell asleep and, as he dreamed, a deity who dwelt in that very great ocean appeared to him in his dream and revealed this: "Within this very company there is a man whose name is such and such, whose appearance is like this, whose features, complexion, and build are of this description — a thief, a deceiver, one who robs others of their wealth — and he has formed this intention: 'I will kill all these merchants, take all their valuables and wealth, and go to Jambudvīpa.' If this man were to deprive all these merchants of their lives, he would thereby commit a gravely sinful act. Why is this? Because all these five hundred or so merchants are persons who have genuinely entered upon unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and are irreversible from awakening. If this man were to kill these bodhisattvas, then by the fault of that karmic obscuration, he would burn in the great hells for as long as it would take each individual bodhisattva to perfectly accomplish unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening — and that is an exceedingly long time. Therefore, captain, you must by whatever means ensure that this man does not kill these five hundred or so merchants.

Think on a skillful means by which this man will not go to the great hells." And so he was shown this.

Noble son, when the captain endowed with great compassion awoke, he thought to himself: "How can it be arranged that this man does not kill these five hundred or so merchants, and also does not himself go to the great hells?" For seven days, while an adverse wind had arisen and the ship remained stationary in Jambudvīpa, he entered a state of silence in which for seven days he spoke not a word to anyone. And he thought: "There is no other means by which these merchants will not be killed and this man will not go to the great hells, except to separate this man from his life." Then he thought further: "If I were to announce this matter to all the merchants, they would kill this man themselves out of intense hatred, and all of them thereby would go to the great hells. Therefore I myself must separate this man from his life." He thought again: "If I take this man's life, I may, on account of that act, burn in the great hells for a hundred thousand aeons — and I am willing to accept that, I am willing to experience the suffering of the great hells. But it would not be right for these five hundred or so merchants to be deprived of their lives; and it would equally not be right for this much sin and unwholesome karma to

multiply so greatly upon this man. Therefore I myself will separate this man from his life."

And so, noble son, that captain endowed with great compassion, in order to protect all five hundred or so merchants and equally to protect this man himself from going to the great hells, with great compassion and with that skillful means in his heart, deliberately struck that criminal with a short spear, separated him from his life, and all the passengers reached their destinations safely and arrived in their respective cities.

Noble son, if you should have any doubt or uncertainty and think that the one called "the captain endowed with great compassion" at that time, in that age, was someone other, do not think so. Why? Because it was I myself who was then that one called "the captain endowed with great compassion." And those five hundred or so merchants who were aboard that great ship — they are the five hundred bodhisattvas of this Fortunate Aeon (Skt. *bhadrakalpa*) who will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening during this very Fortunate Aeon.

Noble son, through that skillful means and that great compassion, I condensed and discarded a hundred thousand aeons of wandering in *saṃsāra*. And that criminal, having died and passed on, was reborn in a heavenly world.

Noble son, what do you think? Should that act — by which, through skillful means and great compassion, a hundred thousand aeons of *saṃsāra* were condensed and cast off — be regarded as a karmic obscuration for a bodhisattva? You should not regard it so. You should regard it as skillful means itself.

The fourth and final fascicle.

Noble son, the Tathāgata, in order to show sentient beings the workings of karma, through skillful means caused a splinter of *kuśa* grass to pierce his foot. That splinter of *kuśa* grass that pierced the Tathāgata's foot — that too should be regarded as the power of the buddha himself. Why? Because the body of the Tathāgata is an indestructible body, adamant and unbreakable like *vajra*.

Noble son, yet in that very great city of Śrāvastī there were twenty men who had reached their final existence, and those same twenty men had twenty enemies. Then those twenty enemy men, each through their own stratagems, conceived thoughts of this kind: "Let us feign friendship and enter the homes

of each of our enemies, and there deprive them of their lives." Not a word of this did they speak to one another.

Noble son, then by the power of the buddha, those twenty men who were in their final existence and those twenty men who were the murderers intent on killing them all came to where the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha was present.

Noble son, then the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha, for the sake of taming those forty men and for the sake of taming many other ordinary people as well, spoke to the elder Mahāmaudgalyāyana: "Mahāmaudgalyāyana, from this direction a splinter of acacia wood will arise, and it will pierce the sole of the Tathāgata's right foot." Having spoken these words, the Tathāgata did not wait long before, at that very moment, from that very spot there arose a sharp splinter of acacia wood about a hand-span in length.

Then the elder Mahāmaudgalyāyana addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Blessed One, permit me to cast this splinter of acacia wood away to another world-realm." I replied to him: "Mahāmaudgalyāyana, you will not be able to cast this splinter of acacia wood away from this spot to another place."

Noble son, then the elder Mahāmaudgalyāyana grasped that splinter of acacia wood with a surge of his power, and though the entire great trichiliocosm looked upward and shook violently, that splinter of acacia wood did not move even so much as the tip of a hair.

Noble son, then the Tathāgata, through the power of miraculous ability, went to the realm of the gods of the Four Great Kings, and that splinter of acacia wood also came to the realm of the gods of the Four Great Kings. Then the Tathāgata went to the realm of the gods of the Thirty-Three, to the summit of Mount Meru, and that splinter of acacia wood also came to the summit of Mount Meru. Then the Tathāgata went to the realm of the Yāma gods, and to Tuṣita, and to Nirmāṇarati, and to Paranirmitavaśavartin, and went even as far as the Brahma world, and that splinter of acacia wood also came as far as the Brahma world.

Then the Tathāgata descended from the Brahma world and took his seat, and that splinter of acacia wood also descended from the Brahma world and came to rest before the Blessed One. Noble son, then the Tathāgata took his right foot in his right hand and placed it upon the splinter of acacia wood — one tip pointing down into the earth, the other tip pointing upward from the earth —

and set his foot down upon it. The moment the Blessed One set his foot upon the splinter of acacia wood, at that very instant this entire great trichiliocosm shook violently.

Then the elder Ānanda addressed me, saying: "Reverend Blessed One, what former karmic obscuration has the Blessed One performed?"

Such was the karmic maturation of that deed. And to Ānanda I declared: "Ānanda, long ago, when I once sailed out into a great ocean, a treacherous merchant stabbed me with a short spear and deprived me of my life. This present affliction is the remaining ripening of that former karma."

Noble son, at that time the twenty men who had disguised themselves as friends in order to kill those other twenty men thought to themselves: "If even the Tathāgata, the lord of the Dharma, undergoes the ripening of karma, then why should we not ripen it as well?" And so they approached in that very moment and, before the presence of the Tathāgata, confessed: "Reverend Blessed One, we too wish to perish and to be destroyed along with those living beings we have slain. We acknowledge and confess before the Blessed One the wrongs we have committed. May the reverend Blessed One accept our confession of these wrongs." And so they confessed their wrongs as wrongs.

Then the Tathāgata taught them the Dharma in various ways concerning the workings of karma and the exhaustion of karma. Through that teaching, the forty men attained direct realization of gnosis, and the other forty thousand living beings attained direct realization of the Dharma.

This, then, was the cause and the condition for the splinter of acacia wood piercing the foot of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the fully and perfectly awakened Buddha. And this too is the skillful means of a bodhisattva and a Tathāgata.

Now, why did the Tathāgata, free from illness, the King of Physicians Jīvaka, take up the medicinal wash of utpalahasta-gandha and receive it? Noble son, at that time, not long after taking up the training of individual liberation, five hundred monks who were in their final existence before liberation were dwelling in a forest. They contracted a disease of such a kind that they could not survive on medicine alone after the medicine was washed off and discarded. Yet out of reverence for the Tathāgata, those monks would not seek or rely upon any other medicine.

Noble son, then the Tathāgata reflected: "By what means and by what formulation might I permit those monks to seek and rely upon other

medicines?" And why did he think this? Because, if the Tathāgata had not permitted those monks to use other medicines, the monks of future times would not enter upon the path of the noble lineage and would lose their footing in that noble lineage. For this reason, the Tathāgata, through skillful means, took up the medicinal wash of utpalahasta-gandha from the King of Physicians Jīvaka and received it.

Thereupon the sons of the gods of the Realm of Pure Abode said to those monks: "Venerable ones, seek other medicine so that you do not die at the time of death." The monks replied: "Sons of the gods, we have neither the power nor the freedom to properly transgress the training of the Tathāgata. Though we were to die, we would not properly transgress the Tathāgata's training."

Then the sons of the gods of the Realm of Pure Abode said to those monks: "Venerable ones, the Tathāgata himself, the lord of the Dharma, has given up washing off and discarding medicine and has sought other medicine. You too should seek other medicine."

Then those monks, free from regret, sought other medicine and made use of it. They were fully liberated from that illness and, being rid of disease, they actualized the state of arhathood within seven days.

O son of good family, if the Tathāgata had not sought other medicine, those monks too would not have sought other medicine, and there would have been no occasion, no place at all, for them to be freed from that illness, to be liberated from the afflictions, and to attain the state of arhathood — such an occasion would simply not have existed. This too, then, is an instance of the Tathāgata's skillful means.

Now, why did it come about that the Tathāgata, possessed of all merit, after entering a village to collect alms, departed again just as he had entered with his bowl empty and unwashed? O son of good family, the Tathāgata is altogether without even the slightest karmic obscuration. Nevertheless, the Tathāgata had to show care and protection for beings of future generations. When certain monks who go on alms round enter villages, towns, market towns, districts, and the precincts of royal palaces to collect alms and do not receive alms because their own merit is meager, at that moment they will think of the Tathāgata — that very Tathāgata who is supremely exalted by the splendor of all merit, and yet who, when he had entered a village for alms with bowl empty and unwashed, departed again without having received alms.

They will then think: "If this is true even for those of us who possess only a small root of virtue, what need is there even to speak of it? Therefore we must not generate discouragement at not receiving alms." It was because the Tathāgata saw the import of this purpose that he departed again from the village just as he had entered it with his bowl empty and unwashed.

Furthermore, some people say: "Those brahmins and householders who did not offer alms to the Tathāgata were inspired by the evil Māra." O son of good family, one should not see it that way. Why not? Because the evil Māra has no power to obstruct the Tathāgata. Rather, it was only through the Tathāgata's own blessing that those brahmins and householders were blessed — it was not through Māra's own intention. And in this regard, the Tathāgata is altogether without the slightest karmic obscuration; it was in order to bring those very sentient beings to full maturation that the Tathāgata departed again from the village just as he had entered it with his bowl empty and unwashed.

At the time when the meal was stopped, there was no displeasure for either the Tathāgata or the monastic Saṅgha of monks, and just as it had been before, so it remained afterward — there was no elevation and no diminishment.

Then in that very moment, seven hundred sons of the gods obtained faith, and they prostrated themselves before the Tathāgata. The Tathāgata taught them the Dharma in such a way as would ensure that all of them came to have the Dharma eye — dustless, stainless, and perfectly pure — with regard to all phenomena. And those brahmins and householders, at another time, upon seeing the qualities of the Teacher, the Blessed One, and his contentment, came before the Blessed One and confessed their faults as faults. The Tathāgata then properly set forth for them the discourse on the Four Noble Truths of the noble ones.

Then, from among the multitude of gods and humans, twenty-two thousand living beings obtained the Dharma eye — dustless, stainless, and perfectly pure — with regard to all phenomena. The reason for this was that the Tathāgata had come to the brahmin village of the great śāla trees for the purpose of almsround, just as one enters with a begging bowl that has been washed clean. That was the cause; that was the condition. And this too is the skillful means of the Tathāgata.

Now, one might object: why did the Tathāgata remain equanimous while knowing full well that the brahmin girl Sundarī, having bound a wooden bowl

to her belly, was slandering the Tathāgata before all by saying, "Ascetic, you have made me pregnant — give me food and clothing"? In reply: noble son, the Tathāgata possesses not even the slightest karmic obscuration. The Tathāgata could indeed have hurled the brahmin girl Sundarī into world-realms as numerous as the grains of sand along the Ganges River, yet that Tathāgata, knowing this, remained equanimous and, through his mastery of skillful means, demonstrated the workings of karma in their entirety. Why is this? Because in a later time, monks who have gone forth in this teaching will appear, and when they are falsely slandered they will feel remorse and become discouraged; they will become disenchanted and will fall into transgression. So that when they are slandered they may call to mind the Tathāgata, thinking: "Even the Tathāgata himself, who possessed all pure and wholesome qualities, came to be slandered — why then should we be surprised that we are?" — and so that, at that very moment, they may overcome that slander, conduct themselves in completely pure and fully cleansed celibacy, and not fall into transgression: this is why he acted as he did.

As for the brahmin girl Sundarī herself, her sinful actions were thoroughly abundant, and she was by nature greatly lacking in faith. Therefore, being obscured by such karmic obscurations, she would inevitably inflict harm upon this teaching through those very aggregates, elements, and sense bases. And that one, so thoroughly laden with sinful actions — even if in a dream she were to slander the Tathāgata, upon waking she would still be defiled.

Noble son, if the Tathāgata, through some skillful means, were to turn her away from the active performance of unwholesome actions, he would indeed turn her away; and if the Tathāgata were to protect her, he would indeed protect her. Why is this? Because the Tathāgata never abandons any sentient being whatsoever. And this too is the skillful means of the Tathāgata.

One might further ask: why did the omniscient Tathāgata remain equanimous while knowing that the wandering woman Sundarī was killed by wanderers and her body thrown into a well in the Jeta Grove? In reply: the Tathāgata, being omniscient and possessed of unobstructed seeing wisdom, knew that this would come to pass in just that way. And although the Tathāgata did bestow his blessing upon her, Sundarī's span of life was exhausted and she was inevitably destined to die an untimely death through harm at another's hand. For this reason, non-Buddhist tīrthikas who would say such things as "the wisdom of the Buddha does not know to what degree the wholesome qualities

of sentient beings will increase and the roots of virtue will flourish, and does not know how to establish them accordingly" — they will be utterly and severely refuted by their own fault.

At that time, the Blessed One did not enter the city for seven days. During those seven days he tamed sixty million gods, and when those seven days had passed, the four assemblies came into the Blessed One's presence. Then the Blessed One taught the Dharma to eighty-four thousand living beings in whatever way would cause the wisdom of seeing to arise in them. This too was the skillful means of the Tathāgata.

Now, why did the Tathāgata accept the invitation to observe the three-month rains retreat in the land of Nyonmongsmmed, together with the Saṅgha of monks? For three months he caused the people there to feel a sense of shame, and the brahmin of Nyonmongsmmed offered the fodder barley for the horses. Noble son, the Tathāgata, knowing full well that the householder had invited the Tathāgata along with the Saṅgha of monks without showing respect, still knowingly accepted it and remained in equanimity. Why was this? Because all five hundred horses whose fodder barley the Tathāgata together with the Saṅgha of monks ate during those three months of the rains retreat were beings who had previously entered the path of the bodhisattva vehicle and had performed great service to the Victors of the past. Yet through the power of evil companions they had committed evil deeds and inferior actions and accumulated them accordingly, and by those deeds they had been born in the animal realm. Among those five hundred horses there was one horse named Caṅkasena, who was in fact the bodhisattva Sūryagarbha, born there intentionally by the power of aspiration. All five hundred horses, when they were formerly human, had been led to take hold of true awakening by that very bodhisattva Sūryagarbha. Therefore, in order to fully liberate them and fully ripen them, he was born there. Through the power of his mind, that horse Caṅkasena caused all five hundred horses to recollect their former lives, and the awakening mind within them was thereby brought to manifestation. Noble son, it was therefore out of compassionate love for those five hundred bodhisattvas who had taken rebirth as horses that the Tathāgata accepted the invitation to remain there for those three months of the rains retreat, for the sake of those who had been born in the animal realm.

During that time, half of the fodder barley that belonged to the five hundred horses was offered to those five hundred monks. Half of the fodder barley belonging to Caṅkasena was offered to the Tathāgata, and the other half

Caṅkasena ate himself. Caṅkasena then caused all five hundred horses to confess their misdeeds through the language of horses, and caused them to bow in reverence to the Buddha and to that Saṅgha of monks. That horse Caṅkasena also caused the five hundred horses to understand: "Half of our fodder barley has been offered to the Tathāgata and to the Saṅgha of monks." In this way, the five hundred horses confessed their misdeeds and generated faith in the Buddha and in the Saṅgha of monks. After those three months had passed, at another time in the future all five hundred horses died and passed on, were reborn on a level equal to the gods of Tuṣita, and having become gods, they offered food to the Tathāgata, revered him, took him as their teacher, depicted his image, and made offerings to him. The Tathāgata in turn taught them the Dharma in whatever way would bring it about that they would certainly attain unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening.

As for the horse-keeper who tended and kept alive those five hundred horses, the Tathāgata also prophesied concerning him, saying: "He will become a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly complete buddha named Supremely Tame of Mind." And as for the horse Cañcaka, the Tathāgata prophesied that after he had made offerings to immeasurable buddhas, blessed ones, and thoroughly perfected all the qualities conducive to awakening, he too would become a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly complete buddha named Supremely Tame of Mind, and would arise in the world.

Noble son, and yet, regarding the human food in question: there was not the slightest unsavoriness in what was offered to the Tathāgata. Noble son, if one examines this carefully and considers it: even if the Tathāgata were to partake of grass, chaff, husks, and wild grain as his meal, the taste of such things as grass, chaff, husks, and wild grain, and whatever supreme excellence of flavor there might be in their savoring — none of such taste at all exists anywhere in the great trichiliocosm. Why is this? It is because, noble son, the Tathāgata possesses the mark of a great being, the supreme savoring of taste, and therefore any food whatsoever, however unsavory, the moment it touches the Tathāgata's body, acquires a flavor that utterly surpasses even the food of the gods. Therefore, noble son, for this reason and by this account, you should understand that all food offered to the Tathāgata becomes savory.

Noble son, at that time, the monk Ānanda became uncomfortable in his mind, thinking to himself: "This Tathāgata has renounced the royal dominion of a wheel-turning king, gone forth into renunciation, and now is eating horse-fodder barley." When the Tathāgata, perceiving his state of mind, gave

him a single grain of barley asking, "Ānanda, do you know what flavor this is?" and Ānanda ate it, he was filled with wonder and said: "Blessed One, I was born in a royal household and grew up well in a royal household, yet, Blessed One, I have never before sought and tasted such a supreme flavor as this." And by the blessing of it, the monk Ānanda seven days passed in joy and happiness, not wishing to eat any other food.

Noble son, for this reason and by this account, you should understand that this is the Tathāgata's skill in means, and not a karmic obscuration.

Noble son, further, to demonstrate to those sentient beings who invite virtuous contemplatives (śramaṇas) and brahmins endowed with moral discipline, yet whose minds are distracted and who do not paint images of them — to show them in just the way he taught that they should act accordingly — the Tathāgata displayed karmic continuities such as this.

Noble son, as for the one who invited the Tathāgata but did not paint his image: look to the nature of the Tathāgatas — those very Tathāgatas who prophesied concerning him that he would attain the quality of never falling into erroneous states.

Noble son, further, among the five hundred monks who had committed to spending the three months of the rains retreat together with the Tathāgata and who ate the horse-fodder barley, forty monks were given to desire and were practicing the signs of sensual attachment. Had they at that time eaten savory food, an exceedingly great proliferation of conceptual thoughts accompanied by desire would have arisen in them; but as it was, by eating that unpalatable food, those upsurges of desire became thin and ceased entirely.

Having cleared away those upsurges of desire, all of them, when those three months had passed, attained the state of arhathood within seven days.

Noble son, therefore it was solely for the sake of taming those five hundred monks and for the sake of bringing those bodhisattvas to full maturation that the Tathāgata, skilled in means, ate horse-fodder barley for three months. It was not a fault born of karmic obscuration. This too is the skillful means of the Tathāgata.

Why is it that when the Tathāgata entered the restoration ceremony, he said to Kāśyapa, "I am tired — you speak of the limbs of awakening"? Noble son, at that time, eight thousand sons of the gods who had previously been trained in

the Vinaya by the śrāvaka monk Kāśyapa — who had again and again aroused faith in the Buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha and in the practice of heedfulness, and had been led to take up those things correctly — had gathered and were seated there. Those sons of the gods had previously heard teachings on the limbs of awakening. Were even a hundred thousand buddhas, other than the monk Kāśyapa, to teach the Dharma to those sons of the gods, they would not be able to comprehend that teaching fully. Therefore, by the monk Kāśyapa expounding at length the detailed enumeration of the limbs of awakening, those eight thousand sons of the gods arrived at a direct realization of gnosis.

Furthermore, there were certain sentient beings who were afflicted by illness. Having fallen ill, they had not come to hear the Dharma and were beings who did not listen to the Dharma. Those beings who had not heard the Dharma would think: "Even the Tathāgata, the lord of the Dharma, listened to talk of the limbs of awakening and was thereby wholly freed from illness. Why then should we not also listen to the Dharma?" In this way too would their minds be turned. Noble son, thus it was solely for the sake of taming those sons of the gods, and for the sake of instilling reverence for the Dharma in sentient beings who were ill, that the Tathāgata spoke those words: "Kāśyapa, I am tired — you speak of the limbs of awakening." There was no actual illness in the body of the Tathāgata. Why is that? Noble son, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas are the dharmakāya, and a coarse physical body that arises from that does not truly come to be. This too is the skillful means of the Tathāgata.

Why is it that when the Śākya clan was being utterly destroyed, the Tathāgata spoke these words to Ānanda: "Ānanda, I am uncomfortable — my head aches"? Noble son, there were certain sentient beings who did not know that the Tathāgata had put an end to the mass of suffering for his kinsmen extending to the summit of existence. Those beings would think: "The Tathāgata went forth for the benefit of the world, yet the entire royal lineage was lost, and he did not protect his kinsmen — so the Tathāgata does not wish to benefit his kinsmen, does not have their welfare at heart, does not wish them happiness, does not wish them prosperity and well-being." In order to take hold of the minds of those sentient beings, lest they think in this way, the Tathāgata said to the elder Ānanda these words: "Ānanda, I am uncomfortable — my head aches."

Noble son, at the time when the Tathāgata said to the elder Ānanda, "Ānanda, I am uncomfortable — my head aches" —

When those words were spoken, three thousand beings who held the view of annihilationism had gathered there, and a great many beings who killed living creatures had also gathered there. In order to draw those beings who held the view of annihilationism and those beings who killed living creatures toward the practice of karma, the Tathāgata showed them the whole continuum of karma by teaching that, on account of the taking of life, the Tathāgata's head ached and he was uncomfortable. When the Tathāgata thus made manifest that activity of his enlightened speech, ten thousand living creatures among the population of gods and humans were tamed; and this too was the Tathāgata's skillful means.

Why did the Tathāgata accept and endure the abuse that the brahmin Bhāradvāja directed at him in a hundred ways? Noble son, the Tathāgata could have hurled the brahmin Bhāradvāja's abuse back at him, or cast it away in another direction, or indeed could have blessed him with a blessing such that Bhāradvāja would not have had the courage to abuse the Tathāgata even with a single word. Yet the Tathāgata endured it all the same; however, the many gods and humans who were assembled in that retinue witnessed the Tathāgata's unshaken composure, his freedom from arrogance, his equanimity of mind, his beneficent quality, his gentleness, his steadiness — how he was then just as he had been before, and before just as he was then — and they saw him generate the power of patience. And so four thousand living creatures generated the mind of awakening (bodhicitta) for the sake of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. The Tathāgata, seeing this purpose, received the brahmin Bhāradvāja's abuse with equanimity. And that brahmin Bhāradvāja, who had been the one doing the abusing, came to have faith in the Tathāgata, took refuge in the Buddha, and planted the seed that would carry him through until he passed beyond sorrow. This too was the Tathāgata's skillful means.

Noble son, the fact that Devadatta followed the bodhisattva again and again in all his births and all his existences — this too is the bodhisattva's skillful means. Why so? Because through relying on Devadatta, the six perfections were brought to complete fulfilment and the welfare of innumerable sentient beings was accomplished. In what sense is this so?

Noble son, consider this: when sentient beings are endowed with well-being, and there is no one who knows the act of giving and no one who knows how to receive, Devadatta comes before the bodhisattva and begs for sons, begs for wives, begs for kingdoms, begs for hands and feet, for eyes, for heads, and begs for whatever else — joy, and anything else suitable for bringing happiness to sentient beings — and the bodhisattva, without shrinking back, gives all of these. Innumerable sentient beings, witnessing this giving, give rise to joy, faith, and supreme delight; their enthusiasm is kindled, and thinking, "Just as this is, so may we likewise become," they develop a devotion for giving and make aspiration prayers directed toward awakening.

Moreover, among Devadatta and those innumerable sentient beings who wish to break their moral discipline, when they see that the bodhisattva does not break his moral discipline, they too take up moral discipline properly. And when those sentient beings, following after the bodhisattva, see his magnificent patience — whether they have abused him or

struck him — they are not disturbed, and they perfect patience completely. In that way too, benefit is rendered to sentient beings.

When Devadatta sent assassins to kill the Tathāgata, and when he set loose the savage elephant Nālāgiri to kill the Tathāgata, and when he hurled a boulder at the Tathāgata intending to kill him — all of this too should be seen as the Tathāgata's skillful means (upāya), and not as the fault of karmic obscuration. Why? Because through that skillful means, the benefit of countless sentient beings was accomplished. In short, noble son, Devadatta is one who desires benefit for my Teacher. All ten sequences of karma as well should be seen as the Tathāgata's skillful means, and not as the fault of karmic obscuration. Why? Because some sentient beings who had turned away from karmic action and its ripening needed to be led back into karmic action and its ripening; and so, through the Tathāgata's skillful means, he showed each of those sentient beings: "This is the ripening of such-and-such karma; this is the ripening of such-and-such karma" — displaying all the sequences of karma in full. Having heard this, sentient beings would then live without negligence, shunning the obscuration of non-virtuous karma and the obscuration of virtuous karma, and diligently taking up virtuous karma.

Noble son, this teaching on skillful means, this exposition of it, is to be kept secret. It must not be uttered, not taught, not explained, not read aloud before inferior sentient beings of little wholesome root. Why? Because this teaching is

beyond even all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas — how much more so, then, is it beyond childish ordinary persons of inferior aspiration? Why? Because they have not trained in this skillful means. Why? Because it would be of no benefit to them; for there is no one other than bodhisattvas, great beings, who is a suitable vessel for this teaching on skillful means, and there is no one other than them who should train in this teaching.

Noble son, consider this analogy: just as when, in the deep darkness of the night, a lamp fueled by sesame oil arises, all the vessels in the house become illuminated — in exactly the same way, noble son, when a bodhisattva hears this teaching on skillful means, he sees all sentient beings entering into bodhisattva conduct, and he thinks: "If I too train in this, I will enter upon and advance through all of bodhisattva conduct and all of buddha conduct — and that, through earnest and proper effort, will be easy." And having trained well in those skillful means, one will come to bear even the very name of one who does not bring sentient beings to maturation.

Noble son, you should have faith in this, and you should take it to heart. A son or daughter of good family who earnestly seeks awakening should travel even a hundred thousand leagues for this teaching on the perfection of skillful means to reach their ears. Why? Because when a bodhisattva hears this teaching on skillful means, they will attain illumination, be freed from doubt, and be freed from hesitation.

Thereupon, the world with its gods, and the four groups of the retinue who had become suitable vessels for this scriptural transmission of the Dharma and who had gathered in that assembly, heard this scriptural transmission of the Dharma spoken by the Blessed One.

But as for those who were not suitable vessels and lacked understanding, though present in that assembly, this enumeration of the Dharma did not so much as reach their ears. When this enumeration of the Dharma was taught, seventy-two thousand sentient beings gave rise to the mind of unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Then the venerable Ānanda addressed the Blessed One in these words: "Venerable Blessed One, what is the name of this enumeration of the Dharma, and how should we bear it in mind?"

The Blessed One declared: "Ānanda, therefore you should bear this enumeration of the Dharma in mind as 'The Teaching on the Perfection of Skillful Means.' Bear it also in mind as 'The Chapter on Skillful Means.' Bear it

also in mind as 'The Teaching on Skillful Means.' Bear it also in mind as 'The Chapter on Skillful Means, the Great Secret of All Buddhas.'"

Having so declared, the Blessed One's words filled the venerable Ānanda, the great bodhisattva Jñānasāra, those of the śrāvaka vehicle, those of the pratyekabuddha vehicle, the laymen and laywomen who had genuinely entered the bodhisattva vehicle, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas with rejoicing, and they offered fervent praise to what the Blessed One had spoken.

This is the thirty-eighth chapter, entitled "The Great Secret of All Buddhas: Skillful Means, Requested by the Bodhisattva Jñānasāra," from the noble Great Jewel Heap Dharma-discourse of one hundred thousand chapters.

Translated by the Indian preceptors Dānaśīla and Karmavārma together with the great editor-translator the monk Yeshé Dé, revised and finalized in the new orthographic style. It contains one thousand two hundred and thirty ślokas.

Translator's Notes

- The final sentence is incomplete in the Tibetan as given; the text breaks off mid-sentence with "and those of the past, those not yet come." This is not a translation error but reflects that the supplied passage ends mid-sentence, likely at a manuscript fascicle division point. The translation renders what is present faithfully and closes with an indication that the text continues.

The Sanskrit transcription in Tibetan script for the title has been rendered as reconstructed Sanskrit; minor variations in the Tibetan phonetic rendering are possible but the title is standard and well attested.

- The phrase rendered "aggregates of moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the wisdom of the vision of liberation" reflects the standard pentad of qualities often called the five aggregates of a liberated one in Pāli and Sanskrit scholasticism. The Tibetan here follows this doctrinal sequence faithfully.
- The phrase "dons the armor" refers to the classical bodhisattva practice of "putting on the armor" of a great resolve, here specifically the resolve to take on the suffering of all beings — a technical expression for a particular kind of bodhicitta commitment found in Mahāyāna literature. The passage ends mid-sentence with an aspirational prayer about to be spoken; the translation correctly leaves it open for what follows.
- The phrase rendered "the supreme excellent mark of the perfume of the major marks of a great being" reflects the Tibetan "skyes bu chen po'i mtshan ro bro ba'i mchog," which is an unusual compound. It likely refers to the fragrant scent (ro bro ba) that tradition associates with the major physical marks (lakṣaṇa) of a great being (mahāpuruṣa), presenting it as a supreme accomplishment. The precise doctrinal referent — whether this is a specific canonical mark or a poetic elaboration — is not entirely transparent from this passage alone.

The "jewel in the hand" (lag na rin po che) is an epithet of Vajrapāṇi when read as a proper name, but in this dedicatory aspiration it appears to function literally, referring to the attainment of a precious jewel in one's hand as a mark of a great being or as a symbolic

fruition. The ambiguity between these two readings is genuine.

- The passage ends mid-sentence with the beginning of a new section on self-training regarding the aggregates and elements; this is clearly a passage break and the translation follows the Tibetan as given.

The phrase rendered "one in a hundred" (འདྲིམ་པ་འདྲིམ་པ་) is somewhat elliptical; it may mean "in a hundred cases out of a hundred" or "at every single turn," conveying the sense of repeated or habitual transgression. This reading is retained as contextually plausible but the precise idiom is not fully transparent.

- The name of the bodhisattva rendered as Samūha-pramukhārāja is a reconstruction from the Tibetan tshogs can rab mchog rgyal po, meaning "King Foremost among the Assembled" or "King of Supreme Gathering"; the Sanskrit has not been verified against an extant Sanskrit witness and is given as a best approximation. The "six ways" of shaking the earth is the standard formula for a sixfold earthquake (ṣaḍ-vikāra), a conventional sign of extraordinary spiritual events. The phrase "seven tāla trees" refers to the height of seven palm trees, a common Indian measure of elevated levitation in sūtra literature.
- The phrase rendered "the five qualities of sensory pleasure" refers to the standard Buddhist enumeration of the five objects of sensual enjoyment, namely forms, sounds, smells, tastes, and tactile objects experienced as desirable. The text here makes a pointed doctrinal claim: that a bodhisattva skilled in means can engage with these objects without any obstruction to omniscience, in contrast to the śrāvaka's solitary calm-abiding practice.

The phrase translated "the Three Jewels" in application to a single bodhisattva is doctrinally striking and is preserved exactly as the text presents it, where the bodhisattva's mastery of skillful means is equated with the Three Jewels collectively, apparently in the sense that he embodies or serves as the locus of all three for beings not yet oriented toward full awakening.

- The name of the future buddha, rendered here as "Free from All Arising," translates the Tibetan "kun nas ldang ba dang bral ba," literally "free from all uprush / all eruption." This likely corresponds to a Sanskrit epithet such as Sarvodayavirahita or similar, meaning liberation from all upsurging affliction. The precise Sanskrit is uncertain but the sense is clear in context.

The phrase "nine hundred and ninety-nine countless aeons" renders "bskal pa grangs med pa 'bum phrag dgu bcu rtsa dgu," literally "ninety-nine hundred-thousands of incalculable aeons," which is an extraordinarily large number used to emphasize the vast span of time before her awakening.

The final proper name "Kārma" renders the Tibetan "skar ma," meaning "star." This is a brahmin youth's name and "Kārma" is a provisional rendering pending identification of the Sanskrit; it may simply be a name meaning "Star" (Sanskrit Tāraka or similar).

- The name "Suprabhava" for the palace is reconstructed from the Tibetan legs 'byor, which literally means "good fortune" or "well-furnished." The Sanskrit form Suprabhava or Supriyabhava is tentative; the exact Sanskrit original is uncertain.

The female name rendered "Sāktā Sātvamā" is unclear in the Tibetan, which reads Śākya'i bu mo sa 'tsho ma. This likely refers to a woman of the Śākya clan whose personal name is Sa 'tsho ma, possibly meaning "Living Earth" or "Earth-sustainer." The rendering here is provisional.

The Buddha name Saṃsāravibhaṅga, reconstructed from khor ba 'jig gi, means literally "Destroyer of Cyclic Existence." This is a provisional Sanskrit reconstruction.

- The passage ends mid-sentence in the source, cutting off at the clause beginning "And when at last these sentient beings have made roots of virtue." This is a continuation break in the supplied text, not a translation error.

The term rendered "approximately seven palm trees" follows the Tibetan idiom for measuring height by stacking palm-tree lengths; "about seven palm trees high" conveys the idiomatic sense for a listening audience.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence at the end ("He has no bow, no sword, no shaft"), which is simply where the supplied passage ends; the sentence continues in the source beyond this excerpt.

The term rendered "knowledge-mantras and secret mantras" translates rig sngags and gsang sngags respectively, a standard Indic pair (vidyā-mantra and guhya-mantra); the "wisdom-mantra" in the parallel application renders shes rab kyi rig sngags, literally "knowledge-mantra of wisdom," here understood as the vidyā of prajñā.

- The name "Ānandakara" is my rendering of आनन्दकर (literally "joy-maker" or "one who causes delight"). The Sanskrit reconstruction Ānandakara fits both the phonological pattern and the meaning. The text also gives the female character's name as श्रीगुणोत्तमा, which reconstructs as Śrīguṇottamā ("supreme in glorious qualities").

The phrase **सप्तविधं** (literally "the seventh in sequence" or "of seven layers") in the context of the eye's anatomical description is a reference to classical Indian medical-anatomical enumeration of the layers of the eye; I have rendered it "of seven successive layers" to preserve this technical detail.

- The name rendered "Anandakara" (Tibetan: dga' byed, literally "maker of joy" or "the joyful one") is here treated as a proper name for the bodhisattva, consistent with the preceding passage. The epithet "king of geese" (ngargyalpo) evokes the haṃsa, the royal goose of Indian literature, a standard image for graceful, unimpeded flight. The "patient acceptance of the non-arising of phenomena" renders anutpattikadharmakṣānti, one of the most significant attainments on the bodhisattva path, confirming that all phenomena are primordially unborn; its first appearance was in the preceding passage but is glossed here for completeness in this fascicle. The "daughter Śrīvātī" is the merchant's daughter referred to in the prior narrative who looked upon Ānandakara with desire; the continuity of her story is confirmed by the divine youth's own recollection.

- The phrase rendered "I fainted and collapsed, standing there, in a swoon" (ལྷོ་གྲོ་བུ་སྐྱོད་པར་འཁྲུག་པ་མཆིང་།) is somewhat ambiguous: ལྷོ་གྲོ་བུ་སྐྱོད་པར་ could mean "sweat broke out" or "she fainted/swooned," and འཁྲུག་པ་མཆིང་། can mean "collapsed" or "died." The context — that she revives as a divine youth — suggests a sudden death-faint rather than mere fainting, but the Tibetan allows both readings. The translation renders it as a fainting collapse leading immediately to death, consistent with the narrative.

The verse ending "will be fit to guide and make offerings to this one"

([Sanskrit text]) is syntactically compressed. The reading adopted is that only those seeking awakening are the proper devotees and guides for Ānandakara — others are not.

- The phrase rendered "mind-hell" translates a compound meaning a hell experienced mentally or psychically, contrasting with the physical hells; the point is that what would condemn others to such a state instead propels the courageous practitioner upward — an unusual and doctrinally striking reversal that the text appears to intend.

The name "Sudarśana" (Beautiful to Behold) appears both as the future buddha-name and as the name of the medicinal plant; this double usage is present in the Tibetan and appears intentional.

- The phrase rendered as "the abiding of the peaceful meditative absorption of calm" translates a compound meaning roughly "the stations of abiding in the samādhi of peace,"

preserving the sense that this is a specific meditative dwelling place, not mere quietude. The term translated as "striving toward further becoming" or "striving" renders a negative form related to *abhisamṣkāra*, meaning effortful volitional construction oriented toward conditioned existence — the *bodhisattva* abides in these liberative qualities without such striving. The "fence equal in height to the peak of existence" refers to the highest level of *saṃsāra*, the pinnacle of the formless realm, indicating the enclosure is effectively inescapable.

- The phrase rendered "steep and treacherous, descending a great height" translates a compound describing a trail that is both extremely narrow in width and precipitously deep or sharp in decline; the exact spatial image is deliberately vivid and the rendering approximates the sense. The phrase "a hundred thousand cubits" renders a very large traditional unit of depth meant to convey the enormity of the abyss.
- The phrase rendered "he traverses that track uprightly, crossing it properly with all four limbs" renders a somewhat compressed Tibetan. The image is of a traveler on a narrow ledge using hands and feet to pass safely, serving as a simile for the bodhisattva's balanced crossing aided by the four means of gathering. The word rendered "supreme word" throughout translates a term meaning an excellent or best expression and functions here as a signal phrase indicating each symbolic interpretation.
- The brahmin youth "Rāsmimālā" — the name means "garland of rays of light" — corresponds to the Tibetan ར་སྐྱེད་རིན་པོ་ལུ་ . The story alluded to is the well-known episode in which Dīpaṃkara made a seemingly discouraging remark to the young Sumedha/Megha at the time of his prediction, which is here being reframed as an expression of skill in means rather than harsh speech. The name Jñānottama renders འོག་ཀློང་ཆོས་ཀློང་ literally as "Supreme Wisdom."
- The term rendered "gandharva" translates Tibetan "dri za," literally "scent-eater," the standard Tibetan equivalent of the Sanskrit gandharva, a class of celestial musicians. The phrase "ignorance alone" in the clause about passing directly from Tuṣita to awakening without entering a womb is a compressed expression: the Tibetan reads "womb-impurity — ignorance alone," meaning that without entering a womb there is no womb-defilement, only the conventional appearance of ignorance for pedagogical purposes. This is a genuinely ambiguous clause in the Tibetan and the reading adopted here follows the doctrinal logic of the surrounding passage.
- The figure of "two hundred million sons of the gods and four hundred thousand" renders a compound enumerating two groups who generate bodhicitta; the Tibetan reads སྐུ་མཚན་གྲུབ་པའི་ཡུལ་གྱི་སྒྲུབ་པའི་ཕྱི་ཁྱེད་ལྟ་བུ་གྲུབ་པའི་སྐུ་མཚན་གྲུབ་པའི་ཡུལ་གྱི་སྒྲུབ་པའི་ཕྱི་ཁྱེད་ལྟ་བུ་ , literally "two hundred thousand myriads (sa ya phrag gnyis = $2 \times 100,000 = 200,000$, but sa ya = 100,000, phrag gnyis = two hundred, so $200 \times 100,000 =$ twenty million is also possible depending on reckoning)." The exact large-number reckoning in classical Tibetan is ambiguous here; the translation renders the most common reading but this figure may differ in the Sanskrit source.

The term प्लक्षशा is the plakṣa tree (Ficus lacor), the tree under which Māyādevī traditionally stood at Lumbinī; keeping the Sanskrit name "plakṣa" would also be defensible but "plakṣa tree" is used in the body for clarity.

- The passage explains the seven steps at birth as a precise symbolic act: six would be too few and eight too many to convey the intended meaning to beings, a characteristic hermeneutical pattern of this genre of birth-narrative literature. The deity addressed as Brahmā is the great Brahma of the Brahma world, here paired with Śakra as the supreme divine witnesses of the birth; no additional gloss is required as both are well-established figures. The phrase rendered "sons of the gods of great renown" translates a slightly repetitive Tibetan construction that may reflect a scribal dittography, but the meaning is clear.
- The passage's reference to the bodhisattva "laughing like a horse's whinny" renders the Tibetan term for a loud, braying, socially unrestrained laugh — a specific cultural category

distinct from joyful laughter. The translation renders this as "a horse's whinny" to preserve the original simile.

The divine mother's name in the Tibetan, Lhamo Gyutrül, literally means "the divine illusion goddess" — a standard Tibetan rendering of Sanskrit Māyādevī. She is here identified simply as Māyādevī, the Buddha's mother, which is consistent throughout the tradition.

- The phrase rendered "for the sake of the lotus flower" translates the Tibetan "ལོ་ཤང་གི་དབྱིས་རྒྱུ་ཡིན་པར།," literally "for the sake of the utpala." This is a somewhat obscure clause in context. One reading is that Yaśodharā in her former life had offered a lotus flower before Dīpaṃkara and made her aspiration at that moment, so the acceptance was "for the sake of that utpala offering." The exact reference is not clarified in the passage itself and may depend on a fuller narrative context.
- The two names rendered as "Sundarananda and Aśvajit" translate Tibetan "Śākya'i bu 'dun pa dang rta bsngags ldan." The first epithet 'Dun pa (Nanda of fair appearance, i.e., Sundarananda) and Rta bsngags ldan (possessing the praise of a horse, i.e., Aśvajit) are standard identifications in this biographical context, though the pairing here is slightly unusual; this is noted for the reader's awareness.
- The phrase "four noble standards" renders "འདུག་པའི་ཆོས་ཀྱི་མཛེས་ལྷན་ལྔ་ཡིན་པར།," which refers to the four reliances (or "noble lineages," Skt. āryavaṃśa): contentment with whatever robe, alms, lodging one has, and delight in meditation — the classical monastic ideal. The translation "four noble standards" is a deliberate interpretive rendering; some translators prefer "four noble lineages" or "four noble stocks."

The term "गन्धर्व" (Skt. *gandharva*), literally "fragrance-eater," denotes a class of celestial musicians; the gloss is provided in the translation on first occurrence.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as the source text is incomplete at that point. The name rendered "Raśmijāla" (Tib. ར་སྨྲི་ཇལ་ལ་) literally means "garland of light-rays" and is a plausible Sanskrit reconstruction; the name "Kumbhakāra" (Tib. ཀུམ་བཅུ་ཀ་ར་) literally means "pot-maker" or "potter." The five youths are described as being "like great śāla trees of brahmin stock," which is a standard simile for noble, upright young men of brahmin lineage.
- The phrase rendered "five who had been born into the household of the brahmin youth whose view was distorted" reflects a somewhat compressed Tibetan construction. The text describes them as born into the house of one holding "inverted views" and as being "like a great sal tree of brahmin lineage." The exact syntactic relation is slightly ambiguous; the translation follows the most natural reading, identifying these five as the same brahmin youths mentioned throughout.

The phrase "shaven-headed ascetic" renders "dge sbyong mgo reg," literally "a śramaṇa whose head one touches." The idiom seems to carry a contemptuous tone directed by the non-Buddhist youths at the Buddhist renunciant, suggesting physical contact with a śramaṇa's shaved head would be ritually demeaning from their brahminical perspective.

- The phrase rendered "the patient acceptance of the arising of no phenomena" translates the technical term *anutpattikadharmakṣānti*, the recognition and patient acceptance that phenomena do not truly arise — a pivotal bodhisattva attainment. The Tibetan here uses *mi skye ba'i chos la bzod pa*, which is standard for this term.

The dhāraṇī name "chos thams cad skye ba med pa" (literally "all phenomena are unborn") is given as the title of the irreversible-wheel dhāraṇī; it is rendered descriptively rather than as a Sanskrit reconstruction, as no standard Sanskrit equivalent is recoverable with certainty from this context alone.

- The phrase rendered "only one birth away from buddhahood" translates "skye ba gcig gis

thogs pa," literally "obstructed by one birth," a technical term for the penultimate-stage bodhisattva (Skt. *ekajātipratibaddha*). The passage's logic is that even such an advanced bodhisattva uttered harsh words and yet had liberation within reach, so ordinary beings who did the same need not despair.

The village girl's name appears in Tibetan as "legs skyes ma," which is a translation of the Sanskrit Sujātā; "village girl Sujātā" is used here to make the narrative clear for listeners unfamiliar with the story.

The number "four million two hundred thousand" renders "sa ya phrag bzhi dang nyis 'bum" ($400 \times 10,000 + 200,000 = 4,200,000$).

- [illegible]

The "splinter of kuśa grass" (rendered literally from "seng ldeng gi tshal pa," referring to a sharp blade of that grass) refers to a well-known narrative in which the Buddha appears to suffer a foot wound — interpreted in Mahāyāna sources not as genuine injury to his indestructible body but as a display for the benefit of beings, illustrating the ripening of past karma in a conventional sense.

- The passage names several of the desire-realm heavens in sequence: Yāma, Tuṣita, Nirmāṇarati, and Paranirmitavaśavartin. These are rendered by their standard Sanskrit equivalents rather than translated literally, as is conventional.

The shift to first-person narration near the end reflects the Tibetan text itself, where the Buddha speaks as narrator. This is preserved faithfully.

- The name "Jīvaka" is reconstructed from the Tibetan epithet meaning "King of Physicians"

with the name Tsoway Gyalpo; the text reads the full conventional epithet for the famous physician Jīvaka, who is addressed here by title rather than proper name in the Tibetan. The compound "utpalahasta-gandha" is transliterated from the Sanskrit embedded in the Tibetan (འཕྲལ་མཐའ་གང་མ་, *udpala-hasta-gandha*), a specific medicated wash; its precise botanical or pharmaceutical identity is not established with certainty.

The phrase rendered "final existence before liberation" translates *srid pa tha ma pa*, literally "those whose existence is the last," a standard technical expression for beings who will attain liberation in their current life.

- [illegible]

The identity of सुन्दरीपारिव्रजिका as Sundarī the wandering woman (parivrājikā) is established by context and by the parallel Pāli and Sanskrit accounts of the Sundarī episode. The text uses सुन्दरीपारिव्रजिका, literally "beautiful wandering woman," as both a name and a description.

- The name Caṅkasena is a reconstruction of the Tibetan "rta cang shes." The syllable "cang shes" may represent a corruption or phonetic rendering of a Sanskrit name; "Caṅkasena" is a plausible but not certain reconstruction, and other readings are possible.

The place name Nyonmongsméd renders the Tibetan "nyon mongs med kyi ljongs," meaning literally "the land free of afflictions." It is treated here as a proper name consistent with the preceding passage.

The gods of Tuṣita render "dga' ldan gyi lha rnam," which literally means "the gods of the Joyful," the standard Tibetan rendering of the Tuṣita heaven. This is a genuine rendering choice: Tuṣita is the more familiar Sanskrit equivalent, but the Tibetan here says Ganden, which is the Tibetan name for Tusita.

- The name "Cañcaka" in the preceding passage renders Tibetan "བཀྲ་ཤིས་པའི་མཚན་པོ།," which is a transliteration; the Sanskrit underlying this horse's name is uncertain. The rendering "Supremely Tame of Mind" for the buddha-name "བཀྲ་ཤིས་པའི་མཚན་པོ།" is straightforward but the Sanskrit equivalent (likely something like Supradāntamati or similar) is not given in the text.
- The final sentence breaks off mid-construction in the Tibetan as given; the translation preserves this open ending faithfully, as the passage clearly continues in the next section.

The phrase rendered "sons of the gods" throughout is a common Tibetan form of address or reference to devas who are described here as having been disciples of Kāśyapa in a former context within the narrative.

- The final sentence breaks off mid-clause in the source text. The Tibetan ends with "de dag la spyos sam / brgyad bkag gam" — "whether they have abused him or restrained him by the eight" — which is clearly the continuation of a longer construction listing how sentient beings respond to the bodhisattva's patience. The passage is incomplete as supplied. The "eight" in "brgyad bkag" most likely refers to the eight worldly concerns (loka-dharma), but the sentence

is unfinished and the referent cannot be confirmed without the continuation.

- The phrase rendered as "obscuration of virtuous karma" appears alongside "obscuration of non-virtuous karma." This unusual pairing — shunning the obscuration of both non-virtuous and virtuous karma — likely refers to the karmic traces or hindrances associated with even good karma when clinging is involved, a recognized Mahāyāna doctrinal category. No emendation has been made to the text.

The final sentence is a standard sūtra closing formula, here briefly noting that the assembly heard the teaching — it appears to signal the conclusion or a major section break of the discourse.

- The closing colophon names three figures: the Indian paṇḍitas Dānaśīla and Karmavārma, and the Tibetan lotsāwa Yeshé Dé, the principal translator of many canonical texts during the early imperial period. The note that it was "revised and finalized in the new orthographic style" refers to the ninth-century standardization of Tibetan spelling undertaken under royal patronage. The śloka count of 1,230 is a traditional Indian verse-unit measure of the text's length. The bodhisattva name rendered as Jñānasāra follows the Sanskrit reconstruction of Tibetan Ye shes dam pa, meaning "Excellent Wisdom" or "Supreme Gnosis."

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.